

Translation Handbook

دليل الترجمة



Translation Handbook

A beginner's guide to translating between English and Arabic

Learn. Practise. Revise. Translate.

دليل الترجمة

مرشد للمبتدئين في الترجمة بين العربية والإنجليزية

First edition, 2026

Translation Handbook: A Beginner's Guide to Translating between English and Arabic

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Preface

The Translation Team of the Guild Professional Club prepared this handbook for students taking their first steps in translation between English and Arabic. It introduces students and beginner translators to the principles, strategies, tools and practical skills they need to begin translating between the two languages. Use it in workshops or on your own.

By the end of it, you should:

- know the basic rules and principles of translation;
- understand the main **differences** between English and Arabic;
- recognise the main **difficulties** that translators meet;
- be able to use practical **strategies and techniques** to solve them;
- be able to check your own work and explain your choices.

The Translation Team

Start here

Translation is everywhere. The medicine leaflet in your home, the subtitles of your favourite series, the menu of a video game and the news you read today have all passed through a translator's hands. Most of the time nobody notices, because a good translation reads as if it had been written in your own language. This book shows you how that invisible work is done, and how you can do it yourself.

It is also very old work. In Baghdad, more than a thousand years ago, the House of Wisdom (بيت الحكمة) brought together translators who put Greek, Persian and Indian works of science and philosophy into Arabic. Centuries later, many of them were translated from Arabic into Latin and helped to shape learning in Europe. You are about to join this long line of translators.

This book is for you if you have never studied translation. You do not need any background: only good English, good Arabic and curiosity. We will start from zero and go one step at a time. In the examples, ✓ marks a good translation and ✗ a poor one, and a note such as (Newmark, 1988) gives the source, listed in the References.

What does a translator actually do?

A translator does more than replace the words of one language with the words of another. A translator interprets meaning, considers the context and the purpose, and decides how that meaning should be expressed naturally in the other language.

Consider this sentence from a news report: *The minister stopped short of ruling out further measures.* Translated word for word, it does not say what the English means:

توقّف الوزير قبل استبعاد إجراءات إضافية. ✗

The translator must first understand what *stopped short of ruling out* means here: the minister did not exclude the possibility of taking further action. A natural Arabic translation is therefore:

لم يستبعد الوزير اتخاذ مزيد من الإجراءات. ✓

Notice what happened. The translator did not translate the words one by one. They understood the meaning, considered the context, and rebuilt the sentence so that it

sounds natural to an Arab reader. That is translation. Everything in this book grows from this idea.

The four steps of every translation

Whether you translate a sentence, a letter or a book, the work usually goes through four steps:

1. **Plan.** Ask who will read your translation and why.
2. **Understand.** Read the text until you know exactly what it means.
3. **Write.** Say the same thing in the other language, in a natural way.
4. **Check.** Read your translation again and correct it.

Your journey through this book (read the parts in order)

1. **First steps** (Part 1): what translation is, how to prepare, how to use a dictionary, and how English and Arabic differ.
2. **Understanding meaning** (Parts 2 and 3): how words carry meaning, and how they work together.
3. **Solving problems** (Parts 4 and 5): the methods translators use when a word or an idea does not travel easily.
4. **Whole texts** (Part 6): how to read and translate a complete text, such as a news report.
5. **Tools and checking** (Parts 7 and 8): specialised terms, technology, and how to check and explain your work.
6. **Films and videos** (Part 9): subtitles and dubbing, the most advanced topic.
7. **Your journey continues:** how to keep growing after this book.

How each chapter guides you

Each chapter opens with **Where we are**, explains each idea with examples in English and Arabic, and gives you questions to **Try it**. It ends with **Remember**, **Words to remember** (all also in the glossary) and **Next**, which shows where the path goes. **Did you know?** boxes share true stories about translation.

Part 1: Getting started

Chapter 1: Translation and the translator

Where we are. This is your starting point. In this chapter you will see what translation really is, the different kinds of translation, and what you need to become a translator.

Step 1: translation carries meaning, not words

Remember the sign in the park (Start here): you did not read out the words one by one; you said what the sign **means**, in good Arabic. That is translation.

Here is what happens when we translate words instead of meaning. English speakers say *Break a leg!* to wish someone good luck, especially before a performance:

Word by word: **اكسر ساقاً** ✗ By meaning: **إبالتوفيق** ✓

Translation is often defined in the same way: “an activity or process of transferring textual meaning from one language to another” (Translation Team, n.d.), or “rendering the meaning of a text into another language in the way that the author intended the text” (Newmark, 1988, p. 5).

From now on, we call the original text the **source text** and your translation the **target text**.

Step 2: a translation is never a perfect copy

No two languages match perfectly, so you can never make an exact copy. You bring the meaning as close as you can. This is called **approximation**. Translation has been described as “saying almost the same thing”, the title of a book on translation (Eco, 2003).

And your translation must pass a basic test: your reader must understand it. If they do not, the translation has not worked.

Step 3: the different kinds of translation

People translate in several ways:

- **Written translation:** translating written texts. This is what this book teaches.

- **Interpreting:** translating speech, while the speaker is talking (simultaneous) or after the speaker stops (consecutive).
- **Sight translation:** reading a text written in one language and saying it aloud in another.
- **Audiovisual translation:** translating films, television and video games, for example with subtitles (Part 9).
- **Localisation:** adapting a product, such as a website or an app, to another country's language and culture.

In a wider sense, even rewording a text in the same language, or turning a story into a film, is a kind of translation (Jakobson, 1959). In this book, we focus on translating from one language into another.

Step 4: what you need to become a translator

Knowing two languages is the start, not the end. A good translator:

- knows both languages well;
- knows both **cultures** well (مُلمّ بالثقافتين);
- is curious and learns about the topic of each text;
- knows many expressions and idioms in both languages;
- keeps practising and checking their work.

This is not a new idea. More than a thousand years ago, an Arabic writer said that a translator must know both languages equally well (al-Jāhiz, 1965):

ولا بدّ للترجمان من أن يكونَ بيّانه في نفس الترجمة في وزنِ علمه في نفس المعرفة،
وينبغي أن يكونَ أعلمَ الناسَ باللغة المنقولة والمنقولِ إليها، حتى يكونَ فيهما سواءٌ
وغايةً.

Remember that a translator is a reader before being a writer: first understand the text fully, then write it again in the other language.

Step 5: who chooses the text?

Sometimes someone asks you to translate a text: a client, an agency or an employer. You are then a **commissioned translator**, and you follow their instructions (Chapter 2). Sometimes you choose the text yourself, such as a poem you love. You are then a **self-initiated translator**, and you make your own choices.

Freelance translators (who work for many clients) and in-house translators (who work for one employer) both do commissioned work, and any translator can also translate a text on their own initiative.

DID YOU KNOW?

More than 2,000 years ago, a decree was carved on a stone in Egypt in three scripts: hieroglyphs, a later Egyptian script and Ancient Greek. The stone was found at Rashid (Rosetta) in 1799. Because scholars could read the Greek, they used it to decode the hieroglyphs in the 1820s. A translation opened the door to a lost language.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. What is the difference between translation and interpreting?
2. A publisher asks you to translate a novel. Are you a commissioned or a self-initiated translator?
3. Why is translation called “approximation”?

Check your answers

1. Translation deals with written texts; interpreting deals with speech.
2. Commissioned: the publisher chose the text and asked you to translate it.
3. Because no two languages match perfectly, so the translator can only come as close as possible to the original meaning.

REMEMBER

- Translation carries **meaning**, not words, from one language to another.
- A good translator needs two languages **and** two cultures.
- Commissioned translators follow the client's instructions; self-initiated translators choose their own texts.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Translation** (الترجمة): Transferring meaning from one language into another. In a narrow sense, written translation (الترجمة التحريرية), as opposed to interpreting.
- **Interpreting** (الترجمة الشفهية): Transferring spoken language into another language.
- **Source text (ST)** (النص المصدر): The original text that you translate.
- **Target text (TT)** (النص الهدف): Your translation.
- **Approximation** (التقريب): Rendering the meaning of the source text as closely as possible in the target language, knowing that an exact match is impossible.
- **Commissioned translator** (مترجم بتكليف): A translator who translates a text at someone else's request.
- **Self-initiated translator** (مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية): A translator who chooses a text to translate on their own initiative.

NEXT Chapter 2: Tips, advice and preparation

Chapter 2: Tips, advice and preparation

Where we are. You now know what translation is. Before you translate your first sentence, you need to prepare. This chapter walks you through what to do before, during and after translating, and ends with your first complete translation.

Before you start: ask three questions

A news report for experts and a leaflet for children need different words. The purpose of a translation decides how it should be translated (Nord, 1997). You will meet this idea again in Chapter 26. So before you write anything, ask:

1. **Who is the client?** (من هو العميل؟) Clients have their own style and rules.
2. **What is the translation for?** (ما الغرض التواصل؟) To inform, to persuade, to instruct or to entertain?

3. **Who will read it?** (من هو الجمهور المستهدف؟) Experts or the general public?
Adults or children?

The answers are your **translation brief**. If nobody gives you one, ask. If you chose the text yourself, answer the questions yourself.

For example, a short news report translated for KUNA, the Kuwait News Agency, informs English readers interested in Kuwait. So the translation should be formal and neutral, with a short headline.

Next: get to know the text

1. **Read the whole text** once, just to understand it.
2. **Read it again with a pen.** Mark difficult words, idioms, names and numbers.
3. **Find out about the topic** if you do not know it well.
4. **List the key terms** and check them in a dictionary (Chapters 3 and 21).
5. **Picture the translation:** imagine how it should sound. This is your **mental draft**.

While you translate

Break a long text into smaller pieces: paragraphs into sentences, sentences into phrases. Work out what each piece means, then rebuild it in the other language. Keep the links between sentences, such as cause and effect.

Good habits from experienced translators:

- **Be faithful** (الأمانة): do not add or remove meaning. Aim to be faithful, accurate and acceptable to the reader.
- **Write naturally:** the result should usually read as if it had been written in the target language.
- **Tread carefully:** translation is like a minefield (الترجمة كحقل ألغام). Know what is appropriate in both cultures.
- **Translate everything**, including titles, captions and notes. Keep titles short, and do not add to them.
- **Keep it simple.**

After you translate

Always read your translation again, even when you think it is perfect (Chapter 23). Poetry often allows more creative freedom, but informative texts, such as reports and instructions, must be exact. Good translators combine quality and speed, and that builds their reputation.

Your first translation, step by step

Now let us put it all together on one short sentence:

It's raining cats and dogs, so the match has been cancelled.

1. **Plan.** A school is informing Arabic-speaking parents about the match, so the Arabic should be clear and simple.
2. **Understand.** *Raining cats and dogs* is an idiom meaning “raining heavily”. It has nothing to do with animals (Chapter 9).
3. **Write.** A word-by-word version, إلغاء المباراة، لذلك تمّ إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً،. makes no sense. A translation of the meaning works: أُلغيت المباراة بسبب الأمطار الغزيرة.
4. **Check.** Read the Arabic without the English: the meaning is complete and the sentence sounds natural.
5. **Explain,** if you are asked why: “The idiom was translated by its meaning, because a word-for-word version would make no sense to Arabic-speaking readers” (Chapter 25).

You have just translated your first sentence the way professionals do. The rest of the book helps you do each step better.

DID YOU KNOW?

The *Universal Declaration of Human Rights* has been translated into more than 500 languages, which makes it one of the most translated documents in the world.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. A hospital asks you to translate a medicine leaflet for its patients. Who is the target audience, and what style should you use?
2. What is the purpose of an advert?
3. Why should you read the whole text before you start translating?

Check your answers

1. Patients from the general public, so use a clear, simple style with exact words.
2. To persuade.
3. To understand it, find the difficult parts in advance, and form a mental draft.

REMEMBER

- Ask three questions first: **client, purpose, audience**.
- Read the whole text at least twice before you translate.
- Be faithful, write naturally, and always revise.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Client** (العميل): The person or organisation that asks for a translation.
- **Communicative purpose** (الغرض التواصلي): What the translation is for: to inform, persuade, instruct or entertain.
- **Target audience** (الجمهور المستهدف): The people who will read the translation.
- **Translation brief** (موجز الترجمة): The client's instructions for a translation: who it is for, what it is for and any other requirements.
- **Mental draft** (المسودة الذهنية): A first idea of the translation that you form while reading the text.

NEXT Chapter 3: Printed and digital dictionaries

Chapter 3: Printed and digital dictionaries

Where we are. In Chapter 2 you checked key terms in a dictionary. This chapter shows you which dictionaries to use, and how to choose the right meaning.

Step 1: a dictionary gives options, not answers

A famous saying goes: “Dictionaries are like watches; the worst is better than none, and the best cannot be expected to go quite true” (Johnson, 1784/1897, p. 309). So do not simply take the first meaning. Use the three-check rule:

1. Find the options in a **bilingual dictionary**.
2. Confirm the meaning in a **monolingual dictionary**.
3. See how the word is really used in a text written in the target language.

For example, for *a fast colour* a bilingual dictionary gives سريع and ثابت. An Arabic dictionary confirms that ثابت can mean “not fading”, and clothing labels use لون ثابت. So the answer is لون ثابت.

Step 2: printed or digital?

- **Printed dictionaries:** edited by experts, with full entries and examples, but slower to use, and they may lack new words.
- **Digital dictionaries:** fast and often updated, but quality varies. Check the publisher: a digital version of a known printed dictionary is safer than an unknown website.

Step 3: dictionaries to start with

- *Al-Mawrid* (Baalbaki, n.d.): English–Arabic, for general words.
- *A Dictionary of Modern Written Arabic* (Wehr, 1994): Arabic–English, with words listed by root.
- *Al-Muʿjam al-Wasīṭ* (المعجم الوسيط) (Academy of the Arabic Language in Cairo, n.d.): a monolingual Arabic dictionary from the Academy in Cairo.
- *Oxford Collocations Dictionary for Students of English* (2009): natural English word partners.
- UNTERM (United Nations, n.d.) and Arabterm (ALECSO & GIZ, n.d.): official and technical terms. For one field, such as law or medicine, add a **specialised dictionary**.

DID YOU KNOW?

One of the earliest Arabic dictionaries, كتاب العين, was compiled in Basra in the eighth century. It does not follow the alphabet: it orders the letters by where they are pronounced, from the throat to the lips. It begins with the letter ع, which gives the book its name.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Which dictionary do you use to confirm a meaning?
2. What should you check before trusting a digital dictionary?

Check your answers

1. A monolingual dictionary.
2. Who publishes it.

REMEMBER

- Check a bilingual dictionary, then a monolingual one, then a real text.
- Use printed and digital dictionaries together; check digital sources.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Bilingual dictionary** (معجم ثنائي اللغة): A dictionary that gives equivalents in another language.
- **Monolingual dictionary** (معجم أحادي اللغة): A dictionary that explains words in the same language.
- **Specialised dictionary** (معجم متخصص): A dictionary for one field, such as law or medicine.
- **Collocations dictionary** (معجم المتلازمات اللفظية): A dictionary of the natural word partners of a language.

NEXT Chapter 4: English and Arabic: key differences

Chapter 4: English and Arabic: key differences

Where we are. You know how to prepare a translation. But English and Arabic work differently, and most beginners' mistakes come from these differences. This chapter shows you the main ones, so you can avoid them (Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999/2011; Ghazala, 2008).

Step 1: put the sentence in the right order

English usually puts the subject first (Subject-Verb-Object). Formal Arabic often starts with the verb (Verb-Subject-Object), although starting with the subject is also correct. A sentence that starts with a verb is called a **verbal sentence**, and in Arabic it often sounds more natural:

Sam ate the cake. → أكلَ سامٌ الكعكةَ (correct, but less usual) ✓

Ali often goes to bed early. → ينامُ عليٌّ مبكراً (the verb comes first, and *goes to bed* becomes simply ينام, not يذهب إلى الفراش)

Length differs too. English often prefers shorter sentences. Arabic often joins several ideas in one long sentence with *و* and *ثمّ*. So join short sentences when you translate into Arabic, and split long ones when you translate into English.

Linking words help your Arabic flow: *بالإضافة إلى* (in addition), *لذلك* (therefore), *غير أنّ* (however), *على سبيل المثال* (for example).

Step 2: the small verbs “be”, “do” and “have”

In the present tense, English needs *is* and *are*; Arabic normally leaves them out:

Translation is a fascinating field → الترجمةُ مجالٌ شائق. In formal writing, *تُعدّ* (“is considered”) is also possible when the sentence gives an opinion: *تُعدّ الترجمةُ مجالاً شائقاً*. Into English, add the verb: *الطلاب في المختبر* → *The students are in the laboratory*.

Do not translate a simple *is*, *am* or *are* with *يكون*: *She is kind* → إنها طيبة, not هي تكون طيبة; *I am leaving now* → سأغادر الآن. In the past, use *كان*: *The child was sick* → كان الطفلُ مريضاً.

Do and *have* also need care:

- In negatives and questions, *do* has no Arabic word of its own: *Do not touch it* → لا تلمسه; *She did not eat* → لم تأكل; *Do you want to play?* → هل تريد أن تلعب؟
- As a main verb, *do* has a meaning: *I will do my best* → سأبذل قصارى جهدي.
- The meaning of *have* depends on its object: *She had a nice holiday* → قضت عطلة جميلة; *She has her pills on time* → تتناول الحبوب في الوقت المحدد; *She has money* → تملك مالاً.

Step 3: show gender and number

Each language chooses what its grammar must show, such as gender and number (Baker, 2018). English often leaves these out; Arabic cannot.

- English *you* can be أنت (one man), أنتِ (one woman), أنتم (two people), أنتم (three or more men, or a mixed group) or أنتن (three or more women). Arabic must show gender and number; English need not. In other words, “languages differ essentially in what they must convey and not in what they may convey” (Jakobson, 1959, p. 236).
- With the numbers 3 to 10, the number takes the opposite gender to the singular noun: ثلاث طالبات but ثلاثة طلاب.
- Arabic has a dual (المحكمان, the two arbitrators); English uses two.
- English *I* and *you* do not show gender, but Arabic verbs and adjectives do: *I am a student* → أنا طالب or أنا طالبة. If the sentence does not say, look for clues in the whole text: a name, a title such as *Mr* or *Mrs*, a word such as *husband* or *wife*.
- Some feminine job titles have another meaning (نايبة can mean “calamity”; قاضية can mean “fatal”), so some writers avoid them. Today, however, قاضية and نائبة are widely used for women judges and members of parliament.

Step 4: watch out for small words and paired words

Some common English words must not be translated with their first dictionary meaning:

- *He is in bed.* → إنه في فراشه or, depending on context, إنه نائم (rather than إنه في السرير)

- *As an officer, I...* → بصفتي ضابطاً...; *As the manager of the company, I...* → بصفتي مدير الشركة (here *as* means a role, not *ك*)
- *Shops stay open.* → تظل المحلات التجارية مفتوحة (*stay* means “remain”, not “live”)
- *Eventually* → في نهاية المطاف (it means “in the end”, not “possibly”)
- *...to see the Roman ruins* → لزيارة الآثار الرومانية (Arabic prefers “visit”)

Arabic often places two synonyms side by side for emphasis; English does this much less often. So شجاعٌ مِغوار becomes *very brave*, not *brave and daring*.

Step 5: choose the right Arabic and its punctuation

Choose the kind of Arabic that suits the text:

- **Classical Arabic** (العربية الفصحى التراثية): the Arabic of the Qur'an and classical poetry.
- **Modern Standard Arabic** (الفصحى المعاصرة): the Arabic of newspapers, laws and education. In most written translation, this is the right choice.
- **Dialects** (اللهجات العامية): everyday spoken Arabic. Use one when the client, the audience or the medium calls for it, for example in dubbing a cartoon or a series, or in some advertising.

Use Arabic punctuation in Arabic texts: the Arabic comma , , semicolon ؛ and question mark ؟.

Most translation problems between English and Arabic fall into four groups: **grammar** (النحو), **word choice** (اختيار المفردات), **punctuation and style**, and **general or technical texts**. Style includes how formal the language is: its **register**.

DID YOU KNOW?

The digits 0 to 9 used in English are called *Arabic numerals*, because Europe learned them from Arabic books; they first developed in India. Much of the Arab world writes the same digits in another form: ٩ ٨ ٧ ٦ ٥ ٤ ٣ ٢ ١ ٠.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Rewrite as a verbal sentence: الطلاب حضروا المحاضرة.
2. Translate: الطلاب في المختبر.
3. Translate: *He is in bed.*

Check your answers

1. حضر الطلابُ المحاضرة. (When the verb comes first, it stays singular: حضر, not حضروا.)
2. *The students are in the laboratory.*
3. إنه نائم, or, if the context shows he is asleep, إنه في فراشه.

REMEMBER

- **EN → AR**, as a general tendency: a verbal sentence often sounds more natural; a simple *is* is not translated with يكون; short sentences can be joined; use Arabic punctuation.
- **AR → EN**, as a general tendency: start with the subject, split long sentences, turn a pair of synonyms into one expression, add “is”.
- In most written translation, use Modern Standard Arabic; the text type, the audience, the purpose and the medium can call for a dialect.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Word order** (ترتيب الكلمات): The order of the subject, verb and object in a sentence.
- **Verbal sentence** (الجملة الفعلية): A sentence that starts with a verb.
- **Register** (المستوى اللغوي): How formal or informal the language is.
- **Modern Standard Arabic (MSA)** (الفصحى المعاصرة): The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education.
- **Dialect** (اللهجة العامية): The everyday spoken Arabic of a country or region.

NEXT *The translator's workflow*

The translator's workflow

Use these seven steps for every translation, from a sign to a report. Each step is explained in the chapter shown.

1. **Read** the whole text before you translate a word (Chapter 2).
2. **Analyse** it: who wrote it, for whom, why, and in what style (Chapter 18).
3. **Research** the words and terms you are not sure of (Chapters 3 and 21).
4. **Draft** your translation with the reader and the purpose in mind (Chapters 2 and 5).
5. **Check** it against the source: nothing missing, nothing added (Chapter 23).
6. **Revise** it until it reads naturally in the target language (Chapter 23).
7. **Deliver** it, with a short commentary if the client needs one (Chapter 25).

Never translate a word before you understand the text.

DO

- ✓ Read the whole text first.
- ✓ Check the context of every word.
- ✓ Research terms in reliable sources.
- ✓ Keep one term for one idea.
- ✓ Revise before you deliver.

DON'T

- ✗ Translate word by word.
- ✗ Trust the first meaning in the dictionary.
- ✗ Assume that a machine translation is correct.
- ✗ Change a term only for variety.
- ✗ Submit your first draft.

Part 2: Understanding meaning

Chapter 5: Form and meaning

Where we are. In Chapter 4 you often changed a sentence's structure. This chapter gives you the rule that makes such changes safe, so you can change the form without losing the meaning.

Step 1: meaning comes first

The shape of a sentence is its **form**; the idea behind it is its **meaning**. In translation we favour meaning over form (المعنى أهم من الشكل): you may change the form, but never the meaning.

Anything said in one language can be said in another, unless the form itself is part of the message, as in a poem's rhyme (Nida & Taber, 1969).

Step 2: change the form when you need to

Copying the English form often gives clumsy Arabic, so change it. For example, a noun can become a verb:

- *He is a heavy smoker.* → يدخن بشراهة (the noun *smoker* becomes the verb يدخن, and the adjective *heavy* becomes بشراهة)
- *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل (the noun *arrival* becomes a verb; see Chapter 13)

Step 3: when the image does not travel

Sometimes the problem is a picture. The British press called Tony Blair *Bush's poodle*: someone who obediently follows George Bush. A poodle has no such meaning in Arabic, so the translator keeps the meaning and changes the form: تابع بوش or بليز، المنقاد لبوش.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Translate by changing the form: *He is a fast runner.*
2. Translate by changing the form: *His arrival was late.*

Check your answers

1. يركض بسرعة.
2. وصل متأخراً.

REMEMBER

- Meaning comes before form.
- You may change the structure, but never the meaning.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Form** (الشكل): The structure of language: a word, phrase, clause, sentence or text.
- **Meaning** (المعنى): The idea that a form expresses.

NEXT Chapter 6: Types of meaning

Chapter 6: Types of meaning

Where we are. Meaning comes before form, but meaning has layers. This chapter shows you three of them, so you can choose words with the right feeling and translate what a speaker really means.

Step 1: same meaning, different feeling

Die and *pass away* say the same thing but feel different. The basic meaning is the **denotation**; the feeling is the **connotation**. These are sometimes called propositional and expressive meaning (Baker, 2018). Choose the word with the right feeling as well as the right meaning:

- *die* (مات) is neutral; *pass away* (تُوفِّي) is polite and respectful; *kick the bucket* is informal and humorous.
- *steed* (جواد) suggests a fine, noble horse; *horse* (حصان) is neutral.
- *friend* (صديق) is general; *comrade* (رفيق) suggests a member of the same party or cause.
- *slim* (رشيق) is positive; *skinny* (هزيل) is negative.

Step 2: what the words say and what the speaker means

أشعرُ بالحرِّ states a fact, but the speaker may mean “Please turn on the air conditioning”. أصبح الجوُّ بارداً may mean “Please turn it off”, and *It's freezing in here* may mean “Please close the window”.

What the words say is the **sentence meaning**; what the speaker intends is the **speaker meaning**. Translate so that your reader understands what the speaker means. If the indirect sentence works the same way in the target language, keep it indirect.

Step 3: when a single word causes trouble

Some problems appear at the level of the single word (Baker, 2018):

- **No equivalent word:** English has *orphan* and *widow*, but no single word for ثكلى, a mother who has lost a child. This is called a **lexical gap**. Give the meaning: *a bereaved mother*.
- **A false equivalent:** الهنود الحمر is neutral in Arabic, but *Red Indians* is offensive in English. Use *Native Americans*.
- **A rare word:** شبر has an exact English equivalent, *span*, but few readers know it. Use a familiar measure: *about 23 centimetres*.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. In an obituary, which is better: مات or تُوفِّي؟
2. What might a guest mean by saying *It's rather warm in here*?

Check your answers

1. تُوفِّي, because it is respectful.
2. A polite request to open a window or turn on the air conditioning.

REMEMBER

- Check the **connotation** of a word, not only its dictionary meaning.
- Make sure your reader understands what the speaker means, not only what the sentence says.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Denotation** (المعنى المعجمي): The basic, dictionary meaning of a word.
- **Connotation** (المعنى الإيحائي): The extra feeling or association a word carries.
- **Sentence meaning** (معنى الجملة): What the words of a sentence say.
- **Speaker meaning** (مقصد المتكلم): What the speaker really means by saying it.
- **Lexical gap** (الفجوة المعجمية): A concept that has a word in one language but not in the other.

NEXT Chapter 7: Context

Chapter 7: Context

Where we are. Chapter 6 showed that meaning has layers. Many words also have several meanings. This chapter shows you how to use the words around it, and the wider situation, to choose the right meaning.

Step 1: every situation has its own words

Everything around a word, in the text and outside it, is its **context**. Always pay attention to it. As the Arabic saying goes, لكلّ مقام مقال: every situation has its own way of speaking.

Step 2: look near, then look far

- **Near:** the words and sentences around a word. This is the **micro context**, or co-text.
- **Far:** the author (for example Nizar Qabbani or Mahmoud Darwish), the audience, the time and place of writing, and the social and historical background. This is the **macro context**.

Picture a triangle with the **author**, the **text** and the **audience** at its three corners. The **translator** stands in the middle and must know all three.

Step 3: use context to choose the right meaning

A word's meanings may be unrelated (**homonymy**) or related (**polysemy**). Either way, context tells you which one is right.

- *bank*: مصرف (for money) or ضفة النهر (of a river). The meanings are unrelated.
- *case*: حالة (a situation), قضية (an issue or a court case) or علبة (a container, such as a glasses case). The first two meanings are related; the third is not.
- عين: an eye, a water spring or a spy.
- خط: a line, handwriting, a font or a route.
- تطهير: cleaning a wound (تطهير الجرح) or purifying from sins (التطهير من الذنوب). The meanings are related.
- احتجاز: holding water (احتجاز المياه) or holding hostages (احتجاز الرهائن).

DID YOU KNOW?

The English verb *run* has hundreds of senses in the *Oxford English Dictionary*: you can run a race, a company, a risk or a temperature. Only the context tells you which one a sentence means.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. *The doctor examined the case.* Which meaning of *case* is used here, and how would you translate the sentence?
2. شربنا من عين ماء باردة. Which meaning of *عين* is used here, and how would you translate the sentence?

Check your answers

1. The context (a doctor) shows that *case* means a patient's condition, not a container or a court case: فحص الطبيب الحالة.
2. The context (drinking cold water) shows that *عين* means a water spring, not an eye: We drank from a cold water spring.

REMEMBER

- Context decides which meaning is correct.
- Look at the words around a word (micro context) and at the whole situation (macro context).

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Context** (السياق): Everything around a word or text that helps us understand it: the surrounding words and the wider situation.
- **Micro context (co-text)** ((السياق اللغوي (الداخلي)): The words and sentences immediately around a word.
- **Macro context** ((سياق الموقف (الخارجي)): The wider situation: the author, audience, time, place and circumstances of a text.
- **Homonymy** (المشترك اللفظي): One word with several meanings that are not related.
- **Polysemy** (تعدد المعنى): One word with several meanings that are related.

NEXT Chapter 8: Collocation

Part 3: Words that go together

Chapter 8: Collocation

Where we are. Some words appear together so often that they become partners. This chapter shows you how to recognise these partners and translate them naturally.

Step 1: notice the company a word keeps

Words that naturally go together form a **collocation**. It has been defined as “the company a word keeps” (Translation Team, n.d.). The idea comes from linguistics: “You shall know a word by the company it keeps” (Firth, 1957, p. 11). Each language has its own partners, so a collocation often cannot be translated word by word (Baker, 2018).

The basic meaning of *pay* is to give money, but its partners change its meaning:

- *pay money* → يدفع المال (the basic meaning)
- *pay attention* → يُدفع الانتباه (not يُعير انتباهه or ينتبهه)
- *pay respect* → يُبدي احتراماً
- *pay a visit* → يدفع زيارة (not يقوم بزيارة)

Step 2: find a new verb for each partner

One English verb may need a different Arabic verb with each partner:

- *deliver a letter* → يسلم رسالة; *deliver a speech* → يلقي خطاباً
- *deliver the news* → ينقل الخبر; *deliver a blow* → يوجّه ضربة; *deliver a verdict* → يُصدر حكماً

Step 3: practise in both directions

EN → AR

- *close cooperation* → تعاون وثيق; *a close friend* → صديق مقرب

- *strong tea* → شاي ثقيل (not شاي قوي); *weak coffee* → قهوة خفيفة; *a rough sea* → بحر هائج
- *a fast colour* → لون ثابت; *a fast friend* → صديق وفّي
- *break the law* → يخالف القانون (more natural than يكسر القانون)

AR → EN

- استل سيفه → *he drew his sword*
- يساورني القلق → *I am worried*
- قدّم استقالته → *he resigned*
- يقطع العلاقات الدبلوماسية: يقطع → *to sever diplomatic relations*; يقطع الإشارة الضوئية → *to run a red light*; يقطع عهداً على نفسه → *to make a solemn promise*
- عقد اجتماعاً → *he held a meeting*

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Translate: *heavy rain*
2. Translate: *deliver a lecture*
3. Translate: عقد مؤتمراً صحفياً

Check your answers

1. (مطر ثقيل (not مطر غزير).
2. يلقي محاضرة (like deliver a speech).
3. He held a press conference.

REMEMBER

- Learn words **with their partners**.
- Translate a collocation with the natural partner in the other language.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Collocation** (التلازم اللفظي): Words that naturally go together; the company a word keeps.

NEXT Chapter 9: Idioms, proverbs and fixed expressions

Chapter 9: Idioms, proverbs and fixed expressions

Where we are. Some word partners go further than collocations: they are fixed, and together they mean something new. This chapter shows you how to recognise and translate them.

Step 1: recognise an idiom

It's a piece of cake means “it is easy”. This is an **idiom**. Its words are frozen: you usually cannot change their order or replace one of them.

A **fixed expression** is frozen too, but its meaning is clear from its words: *as a matter of fact* → في واقع الأمر; *ladies and gentlemen* → سيداتي سادتي; *all the best* → مع أطيب التمنيات. Use the expression that the target language uses in the same situation.

How to spot an idiom:

- It makes no literal sense: *It's raining cats and dogs*.
- It breaks the rules of grammar: *by and large* (“in general”).
- It is a comparison with *like*: *like two peas in a pod* (“very similar”).
- If an expression makes little sense in its context, it is probably an idiom.

Step 2: check the context first

The same words can sometimes be meant literally. *A piece of cake* usually means “easy” (سهل جداً), but at a birthday party it may simply mean قطعة من الكعكة.

Step 3: choose one of five ways

Here are five common ways (Baker, 2018). As a rule, try them in this order, but let the context decide:

1. An idiom with the same meaning and the same form, if one exists: *to play with fire* → يلعب بالنار.
2. An idiom with the same meaning but a different form: *It's raining cats and dogs* → تمطر كأفواه القَرَب.
3. Borrowing the idiom, when readers will understand it.
4. A paraphrase: the meaning in plain words.
5. Omission, only when the idiom adds nothing and cannot be translated.

Some English idioms:

- *It's raining cats and dogs.* → تمطر بغزارة
- *to roll up one's sleeves* → شَمَّر عن ساعديه
- *over the moon* → في قَمَّة السعادة
- *He looks blue.* → يبدو حزينا; *I will go bananas.* → سأفقد صوابي
- *to be in the red* → يعاني عجزاً مالياً
- *to spill the beans* → أفشى السرّ
- *I'm all ears.* → كلّي آذانٌ صاغية
- *Break a leg!* → بالتوفيق!
- *Mark my words.* → تذكّر كلامي
- *to hit the sack* → أوى إلى فراشه
- *to bury the hatchet* → طوى صفحة الخلاف
- *in a nutshell* → باختصار
- *the long and the short of it* → خلاصة القول
- *Don't put words in my mouth.* → لا تتقول عليّ

Step 4: translate proverbs

For a **proverb**, look for one with the same meaning in the other language. If there is none, give the meaning in plain words:

- كالمستجير من الرمضاء بالنار → *out of the frying pan into the fire*
- رجع بخُفِّي حُنين → *he came back empty-handed*
- عصفورٌ في اليد خيرٌ من عشرةٍ على الشجرة → *a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush*
- *Business is business.* → الشغل شغل (informal)

Step 5: translate Kuwaiti expressions

Dialect expressions work like idioms: translate their function, not their words. A dictionary of Kuwaiti expressions gives these English equivalents (*Mu'jam al-ta'ābīr*, n.d.):

- الحجي سهل → *Talk is cheap or easier said than done*
- الحجي معاك ضايع → *It is like talking to a brick wall*
- السالفة أكبر من جدي → *There is more to it than meets the eye*
- الدموع أربع أربع → *bathed in tears*
- الشمس منين طالعة؟ (on seeing someone do something unusual) → *Hell has frozen over!*

In an Arabic text written in Modern Standard Arabic, give the meaning instead: for *الحجي سهل*, write *القول أيسر من الفعل*.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Translate: *It's a piece of cake.* (about an exam)
2. Translate: *to spill the beans*
3. Translate: رجع بخُفِّي حُنين.

Check your answers

1. الامتحان سهل جداً.
2. أفشى السرّ.
3. *He came back empty-handed.*

REMEMBER

- Do not translate an idiom word by word unless the other language has the same idiom.
- First check that the expression really is an idiom in this context.
- For proverbs, look for an equivalent proverb; if there is none, give the meaning.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Idiom** (التعبير الاصطلاحي): A fixed expression whose meaning is not the sum of the meanings of its words.
- **Proverb** (المثل): A traditional saying that gives advice or states a truth.
- **Fixed expression** (العبرة المسكوكة): A fixed group of words whose meaning is clear from its words, such as *as a matter of fact*.

NEXT Chapter 10: Equivalence

Part 4: Methods and techniques

Chapter 10: Equivalence

Where we are. Chapter 9 showed that idioms often lack an exact Arabic match. Here are three ways to translate them, and which to try first.

Step 1: one sentence, three choices

The agreement has remained a dead letter since then. A “dead letter” is an agreement that exists on paper but is never applied. You can translate it in three ways, the three types of **equivalence** (Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999/2011):

- **Formal:** وقد بقيت الاتفاقية حرفاً ميتاً منذ ذلك الوقت. The words are correct, but many Arab readers will not recognise the image.
- **Functional:** بقيت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق منذ ذلك الوقت. A familiar Arabic idiom: the best choice here.
- **Ideational:** لم تُطبَّق الاتفاقية منذ ذلك الوقت. Clear, but the colour of the idiom is lost.

Note: *agreement* is اتفاقية and *treaty* is معاهدة. Keep the difference.

Step 2: more examples

- *You should think outside the box.* Formal: عليك أن تفكر خارج الصندوق (now used in Arabic too). Ideational: عليك أن تفكر بطريقة إبداعية.
- *Ali is second to none in writing poetry.* Functional: علي لا يُشَقُّ له غبار في كتابة الشعر. Ideational: علي لا يُضاهى في كتابة الشعر.

Step 3: which to try first

These three types are the framework this handbook uses (Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999/2011). They are not steps to try in a fixed order: first consider the purpose, the context, the audience and the effect you need, then choose the type that serves them.

The goal is “the closest natural equivalent of the source-language message, first in terms of meaning and secondly in terms of style” (Nida & Taber, 1969, p. 12).

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Which type? *Ali is second to none in writing poetry.* → علي لا يُضاهى في كتابة الشعر
2. Give a functional equivalent: *The agreement remained a dead letter.*
3. Challenge: *The new law is still a dead letter.* Which version suits a formal legal report, and which a newspaper column? (a) لا يزال القانون الجديد حبراً على ورق (b) لم يُطبَّق القانون الجديد بعد

Check your answers

1. Ideational: only the basic idea is kept.
2. بقيت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق.
3. (b) for the legal report: plain and precise. (a) for the column: the idiom keeps the colour.

REMEMBER

- There are three types of equivalence: formal, functional and ideational.
- Choose the one that gives the closest natural meaning for your reader.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Equivalence** (التكافؤ): A match between a source-language expression and a target-language expression.
- **Formal equivalence** (التكافؤ الشكلي): Keeping the form of the original: passive for passive, verb for verb.
- **Functional equivalence** (التكافؤ الوظيفي): Using a target-language expression that serves the same function, whatever its form.
- **Ideational equivalence** (التكافؤ الفكري): Giving only the basic idea, in plain words.

NEXT Chapter 11: Literal and free translation

Chapter 11: Literal and free translation

Where we are. Now you will make the choice from Chapter 10 for a whole text: follow the words, or the message. You will learn when each works.

Step 1: following the words

You can keep the words, changing only what grammar requires. This is **literal translation**. It can be either successful or destructive (قد تكون الترجمة الحرفية ناجحة (أو مدمرة)). It works only when the target language has the same expression:

- *to play a role* → يلعب دوراً ✓
- *to pay a visit* → يدفع زيارة ✗ (يقوم بزيارة)
- *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً شاقاً ✗ (in English, a long day is a tiring one)
- *What are you wearing on your biggest day?* (in a wedding advert) → ماذا سترتدي في أكبر يوم لديك؟ ✗ (ماذا سترتدي في يوم زفافك؟)

Step 2: following the message

Or you can keep the message and change the form. This is **free translation**. It works when the translation still says everything the source says, and nothing more. Compare three versions of one sentence: *Appointing new employees should be done on the basis of equal opportunity.*

- **Too literal:** يجب أن يتم تعيين الموظفين الجدد على أساس الفرصة المتساوية. Every word is there, but the Arabic is awkward.
- **Natural:** يجب تعيين الموظفين الجدد على أساس تكافؤ الفرص. The structure changes; the meaning stays.
- **Too free:** يجب تعيين الموظفين الجدد بعيداً عن المحسوبية والواسطة والمحاباة. It sounds strong, but the source says nothing about favouritism or *wasta*: the translator has added ideas.

Step 3: how free is too free?

The freer the translation, the greater the risk of adding meaning. Each of these goes too far unless the context clearly supports it:

- *Going out can be risky these days.* → a translator who knows the context (for example, a time when a disease is spreading) might write a sentence about the risk of infection.
- *We have had heavy rainfall this winter.* → ينتظرنا هذا العام موسمٌ زراعيٌّ مبشّر بالخير.
- *His parents are not quite happy about what he said to them.* → a sentence about respecting one's parents.

They add an interpretation or a new idea. Translation this free comes close to **adaptation**.

The principle of translating “not word for word but sense for sense” is very old (Jerome, 395/2012), and some of the great Abbasid translators, such as Hunayn ibn Ishaq, followed it too (Baker & Hanna, 2009). As a beginner, translate the meaning, but do not add ideas.

Step 4: the middle way

Between the two, there is **communicative translation**. It “attempts to render the exact contextual meaning of the original in such a way that both content and language are readily acceptable and comprehensible to the readership” (Newmark, 1988, p. 47). In other words, keep all the meaning, but say it the way an Arab writer would. It suits most texts a beginner will meet, such as notices, instructions, news and letters:

- *No smoking* → ممنوع التدخين, not لا تدخين.
- *Wet paint* → الطلاء لم يجفّ، انتبه، not طلاء مبّلل: an Arabic notice gives the warning, not a description.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Is this literal translation successful? *to play a role* → يلعب دوراً
2. Correct: *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً طويلاً

Check your answers

1. Yes: Arabic uses the same expression.
2. لقد كان يوماً شاقاً.

REMEMBER

- Literal translation works only when the target language has the same expression.
- Free translation may change the form, but it should not add new ideas.
- Communicative translation keeps the full meaning and says it naturally.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Literal translation** (الترجمة الحرفية): Keeping the original words, changing only what grammar requires; also called modified literal translation (الترجمة الحرفية المعدلة).
- **Free translation** (الترجمة الحرة): Keeping the message but not the form; also called loose translation.
- **Adaptation (method)** (التكييف): A very free rewriting; some specialists see it as a new text, not a translation.
- **Communicative translation** (الترجمة التواصلية): Translating the meaning in context so that the reader understands and accepts it easily, as a target-language writer would say it.

NEXT Chapter 12: Metaphoric translation

Chapter 12: Metaphoric translation

Where we are. Literal translation (Chapter 11) often fails with images. Here you will learn to spot and translate metaphors and similes.

Step 1: spot the comparison

Comparing things to create a picture is one kind of **figurative language**. A comparison with *as* or *like* is a **simile**: *He is as brave as a lion*. Without them, it is a **metaphor**: *He is a lion*. Poetry is especially rich in metaphors.

Step 2: how Arabic sees it

Arabic rhetoric draws the line differently: *هو أسد* is a concise simile (تشبيه بليغ), because both sides of the comparison are named. *استعارة* names only the image, as in *رأيتُ أسداً يخطب*.

Step 3: translating a metaphor

Follow these steps in order, based on four of the seven standard procedures for translating metaphors (Newmark, 1988; Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999/2011):

1. **If the metaphor is shared** by both languages, translate it literally. *She is a snake.* → إنها أفعى. *My hopes evaporated.* → تبخّرت آمالي. *My paper will see the light of day next December.* → ستري ورقتي البحثية النور في ديسمبر المقبل. *a throbbing headache* → صداع نابض.
2. **If it is not shared**, replace it with a target-language image with the same meaning. *This is the tip of the iceberg.* → هذا غيضٌ من فيضٍ or, when something bad is hidden, وما خفي كان أعظم. Even everyday words differ: the *hands* of a clock are its “scorpions” in Arabic, عقارب الساعة.
3. **Or turn it into a simile**: *He is a rock.* → إنه كالصخرة في ثباته.
4. **If nothing works**, give the basic meaning. This is the last choice, because the image is lost. *The news raised a few eyebrows.* → أثار الخبر استغراب بعضهم.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Translate: *My hopes evaporated.*
2. Translate: *This is only the tip of the iceberg.* (about a scandal)

Check your answers

1. تَبَخَّرَتْ آمَالِي.
2. هذا غَيْضٌ من فيضٍ or وما خفي كان أعظم.

REMEMBER

- Keep a shared image; replace an unshared one; turn it into a simile; give the plain meaning as a last choice.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Figurative language** (اللغة المجازية): Language used in a non-literal way to create an image or effect.
- **Metaphor** (الاستعارة): A comparison without “as” or “like”; using a word in a non-basic meaning.
- **Simile** (التشبيه): A comparison that uses “as” or “like”.

NEXT Chapter 13: The seven translation procedures

Chapter 13: The seven translation procedures

Where we are. Chapters 10 to 12 dealt with whole texts and expressions. Now you will learn seven precise techniques for smaller units, and spot them in a translation.

Step 1: methods and procedures

Literal and free translation are **methods**. Smaller units need **translation procedures**: “while translation methods relate to whole texts, translation procedures are used for sentences and the smaller units of language” (Newmark, 1988, p. 81).

Step 2: the seven procedures

There are seven (Vinay & Darbelnet, 1958/1995), each further from the original:

1. **Borrowing** (الاقتراض): *computer* → كمبيوتر (common in everyday Arabic; formal texts prefer حاسوب)
2. **Calque** (النسخ): *shadow government* → حكومة الظل (the established term, so the translator does not invent another)

3. **Literal translation** (الترجمة الحرفية): *My friend speaks German fluently.* → يتحدث صديقي الألمانية بطلاقة (only the word order changes, as Arabic grammar requires)
4. **Transposition** (الإبدال): *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل
5. **Modulation** (التطويع): *You can't miss it. (giving directions)* → ستجده بسهولة (the literal *أن تفوّته* لا يمكنك أن تفوّته sounds foreign)
6. **Equivalence** (التكافؤ): *A burnt child dreads the fire.* → من تلدغه الحية يخاف من جرّة الحبل (a proverb is translated by a proverb, whatever its image)
7. **Adaptation** (التكييف): *They are like Romeo and Juliet.* → هما كقيس وليلى

Step 3: direct or oblique?

The first three, which stay close to the original, are **direct** procedures; the last four are **oblique**. Use a direct procedure when it gives an accurate, natural result; otherwise, choose an oblique one. Borrowing is used mainly to fill a gap or to keep local colour.

Step 4: one sentence, several procedures

After his arrival in Kuwait, the minister held a press conference at the Sheraton.

بعد أن وصل الوزير إلى الكويت، عقد مؤتمراً صحفياً في فندق شيراتون.

- *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل: transposition
- *press conference* → مؤتمر صحفي: calque
- *Sheraton* → فندق شيراتون: borrowing, plus the added word فندق (addition, Chapter 14)

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Which procedure? *garage* → كراج
2. Which procedure? *the White House* → البيت الأبيض
3. Which procedure? *Parking for residents only.* → ممنوع الوقوف لغير السكان

Check your answers

1. Borrowing (the Arabic word مرآب also exists).
2. Calque: it is the established equivalent, not a free choice.
3. Modulation: the same rule, seen from the other side.

REMEMBER

- Procedures 1–3 are direct; 4–7 are oblique.
- Learn their names: you will use them in your commentary (Chapter 25).

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Translation procedure** (إجراء الترجمة): A technique for translating a word, phrase or sentence.
- **Borrowing** (الاقتراض): Taking a word from the source language as it is.
- **Calque** (النسخ): Translating each part of an expression literally; also called loan translation (Chapter 17).
- **Transposition** (الإبدال): Changing the word class, for example a noun into a verb.
- **Modulation** (التطويع): Expressing the same idea from another point of view.
- **Equivalence (procedure)** (التكافؤ): Describing the same situation with a completely different expression, often an idiom or a proverb; narrower than equivalence in general (Chapter 10).
- **Adaptation (procedure)** (التكييف): Replacing a cultural situation with a familiar one; smaller in scale than adaptation as a method (Chapter 11).

NEXT Chapter 14: Translation strategies

Chapter 14: Translation strategies

Where we are. Some problems need a wider plan than the procedures of Chapter 13. Here you will learn the main strategies.

Step 1: the closest solutions

A planned solution to a translation problem is called a **translation strategy** (Translation Team, n.d.; Baker, 2018). Begin with the closest ones:

1. **Literal and idiomatic translation:** translating literally when the result is natural, and translating an idiom with another idiom when possible. Check the field even for simple terms: *key word* can be *كلمة مفتاحية* or *كلمة دالة*, depending on the field.
2. **Functional translation:** *a dead letter* → *حبرٌ على ورق*; *second to none* → *لا يُشَقُّ له* غبار. When there is no matching expression, give the plain meaning, as in ideational equivalence (Chapter 10): *spill the beans* → *أفشى السرَّ*; *mark my words* → *تذكّر كلامي*.
3. **Cultural substitution** (adaptation, Chapter 13): *They are like Romeo and Juliet.* → *نحو 8* هما كقيس وليلى. Measures can also follow the reader's culture: *5 miles* → *كيلومترات*.

Step 2: add, remove or explain

1. **Addition:** common from English into Arabic, because Arabic style often favours fuller expression (الإطناب), and Arab readers may need information that English readers already have. *the Fed* → *مجلس الاحتياطي الفيدرالي الأمريكي*.
2. **Omission:** common from Arabic into English, where repeated synonyms sound unnatural. *شجاعٌ مغوار* → *very brave*. It is also used to avoid words that would offend the reader. Never omit real information.
3. **Explanatory translation:** use it only when nothing shorter works, because it makes the text longer. It suits cultural and religious terms such as *الزكاة* and *العدّة*, and for dense technical terms (Chapter 16).

Step 3: say it, or leave it implied

Explicitation is “the process of introducing information into the target language which is present only implicitly in the source language” (Vinay & Darbelnet, 1958/1995, p. 342). **Implicitation** is the opposite: information stated in the source text is left implied, because the context makes it clear (Vinay & Darbelnet, 1958/1995).

- **Explicitation, often required:** English you does not show gender or number, but Arabic must: *أنتنّ* or *أنتِ*, *أنتم*, *أنتما*. Read the context to choose.

- **Explicitation, by choice:** *He took the Tube.* → ركب قطار الأنفاق في لندن, for readers who do not know the London Underground.
- **Implication:** *Kuwait's National Assembly* → مجلس الأمة, in a Kuwaiti newspaper whose readers already know which assembly it is.

Make explicit only what the reader needs, and never add new ideas (Chapter 11).

Step 4: no exact word

Translators also use these strategies; the first four come from Baker (2018):

1. **A more general word:** when the target language has no exact word. عمّ and خال → *uncle*, when it does not matter which side of the family he is on.
2. **A more neutral word:** when the source word carries a feeling that would sound wrong in the target text.
3. **Paraphrase:** explaining the meaning in other words. *jet lag* → الإرهاق الناتج عن فارق التوقيت.
4. **Loan word plus explanation:** explain the word the first time, then use it alone: *waqf* (a charitable endowment in Islam). English has also borrowed many Arabic words: *algebra*, *algorithm*, *hijab*.
5. **Compensation:** if a pun or a rhyme is lost in one sentence, create a similar effect elsewhere (Dickins et al., 2016).

Step 5: how local should the text feel?

For the text as a whole, **domestication** makes it feel local to the reader, and **foreignisation** keeps its foreign flavour (Venuti, 1995). For example, in an English text, الديوانية can become *a men's evening gathering* (domestication) or stay *the diwaniya* (foreignisation). Let the brief decide (Chapter 2).

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Which strategy? شجاعٌ مِغوار → *very brave*
2. Which strategy? *Romeo and Juliet* → قيس وليلى

3. Why is addition common from English into Arabic?
4. Challenge: *The Fed raised interest rates*. For a general Arab newspaper, (a) رفع
مجلس الاحتياطي الفيدرالي الأمريكي أسعار الفائدة or (b) رفع الفيدرالي أسعار الفائدة

Check your answers

1. Omission.
2. Cultural substitution.
3. Because Arabic style often favours fuller expression, and Arab readers may need extra information.
4. (b): general readers may not know *the Fed*. A specialist financial readership may accept the short form (a).

REMEMBER

- Choose the right strategy for each problem; do not use the same one everywhere.
- Use explanatory translation only when nothing shorter works.
- Decide, with the brief, whether the text should feel local or foreign.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Translation strategy** (استراتيجية الترجمة): A planned solution to a translation problem.
- **Functional translation** (الترجمة الوظيفية): Translating with a target-language expression that has the same function.
- **Cultural substitution** (الاستبدال الثقافي): Replacing a cultural reference with one that is familiar to the target reader.
- **Addition** (الإضافة): Adding words or information that the reader needs.
- **Omission** (الحذف): Leaving out words that are unnecessary in the target language.
- **Explanatory translation** (الترجمة الشرحية): Explaining a word or expression that has no equivalent.
- **Explication** (التصريح): Stating in the target text information that the source text only implies.
- **Implication** (الإضمار): Leaving implied in the target text information that the reader can understand from the context.
- **Compensation** (التعويض): Making up for an effect lost in one place by creating a similar effect elsewhere.
- **Domestication** (التوطين): Making a translation feel local to the target reader.
- **Foreignisation** (التغريب): Keeping the foreign flavour of the source text.

NEXT Chapter 15: Cultural approximation

Part 5: Culture and new words

Chapter 15: Cultural approximation

Where we are. A translation is never a perfect copy (Chapter 1), and culture makes this harder still. This chapter shows you how to bring cultural meaning close to your reader.

Step 1: translate the feeling, not the picture

I have got the test in the bag is not about a bag: the speaker is sure of success. Arabic says this with a different picture. When a picture carries a different feeling in the other culture, keep the feeling. This is called **cultural approximation**, and it needs a good knowledge of both cultures (Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999/2011).

Often Arabic already has an expression with the same effect:

- *I have got the test in the bag.* → الامتحان في جيبِي (informal); in formal writing, النجاح في الامتحان مضمون: the image changes, the confidence stays
- *Like mother, like daughter.* → البنت تُشبه أمَّها; in informal speech, the Gulf proverb اقلب الجرّة على فمها تطلع البنت لأُمِّها
- *Ali and Ahmad are cut from the same cloth.* → عليّ وأحمد من طينة واحدة
- *a scapegoat* → كبش فداء
- *to sleep like a log* → نام كالقتيل
- *as busy as a bee* → نشيط كالنحلة
- AR → EN: the Kuwaiti welcome العين أوسع من الدار → *Make yourself at home* (Mu'jam al-ta'ābīr, n.d.): the image of the eye and the house is lost, but the hospitality stays

Step 2: when the climate changes the meaning

In a hot climate, relief and joy are linked with coolness. So *The news warmed my heart* becomes أثلَج الخبرُ صدري. Likewise, a translator of Shakespeare's line "Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?" (Shakespeare, 1609) may choose spring for Arab readers: أَشَبَّهَكَ بيوم ربيعِي؟

Step 3: titles, institutions and business words

Titles and offices are **culture-specific items**: each country names them in its own way. Translate the job, not the words:

- *the Home Office* (UK) → وزارة الداخلية البريطانية
- *the Chancellor of the Exchequer* (UK) → وزير المالية البريطاني
- *the Secretary of the Treasury* (US) → وزير الخزانة الأمريكي
- *the Secretary of State* (US) → وزير الخارجية الأمريكي
- *sheriff* (US) → رئيس شرطة المقاطعة

Media and business words, too:

- *watchdog press* → الصحافة الرقابية; *lapdog press* → الصحافة الموالية
- *mocktail* (a drink without alcohol) → مشروب مُنعش بلا كحول
- *product cannibalisation* (a new product takes sales from another product of the same company) → مزاحمة منتج جديد لمنتج آخر للشركة نفسها

Step 4: say what people really say

Use the phrase people actually say in the same situation, in the variety of Arabic that suits your reader:

- *God willing.* → إن شاء الله
- *We are very well.* → الحمد لله، بخير
- *Welcome! It is an honour to have you here.* → أهلاً وسهلاً، شرفتمونا
- *I am sorry for your loss.* → عظم الله أجركم (formal); in Egyptian Arabic, البقية في حياتك
- *Thank you for your hard work.* → يعطيك العافية (Gulf and Levantine spoken Arabic)

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Translate: *cut from the same cloth*
2. Translate: *the Secretary of State* (US)
3. Why does *warmed my heart* become *أثلج صدري*?
4. Challenge: *I am sorry for your loss.* in a formal condolence letter from a Kuwaiti ministry: (a) *عظم الله أجركم* or (b) *البقية في حياتك*?

Check your answers

1. من طينة واحدة.
2. وزير الخارجية الأمريكي.
3. In a hot climate, relief is linked with coolness, not warmth.
4. (a): it is formal and used in the Gulf. (b) is Egyptian spoken Arabic.

REMEMBER

- Translate the effect, not the image.
- Use what a target-language speaker would say in the same situation.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Cultural approximation** (التقريب الثقافي): Bringing the source text's cultural meaning as close as possible to the target reader.
- **Culture-specific item** (عنصر ذو خصوصية ثقافية): A word, custom or reference that belongs to one culture.

NEXT Chapter 16: Descriptive translation

Chapter 16: Descriptive translation

Where we are. In Chapter 15, the other language had a similar expression ready. Sometimes it has no word and no similar custom. This chapter shows you how to explain such a word.

Step 1: when there is nothing to match

English has no exact word for الزكاة, and no identical custom. So you describe the meaning. This is called **descriptive translation** (Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999/2011):

1. **Transliterate** the source word, for example *zakat*.
2. **Describe** its meaning, in brackets after the word or in a footnote.
3. Describe it **only the first time**. After that, the transliterated word is enough.

Step 2: see it done

- الزكاة → *zakat* (obligatory annual alms in Islam: a fixed share of savings and wealth above a minimum amount, given to those in need)
- التيمم → *tayammum* (dry ritual purification: wiping the face and hands with clean earth when water is missing or cannot be used)
- البسملة → *the basmala* (saying “In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful”)
- الحوقلة → *the hawqala* (saying “There is no might and no power except by God”)
- العدة → *‘idda* (the waiting period before a divorced or widowed woman may remarry)
- العطوة → *‘atwa* (a temporary truce in tribal customary law, for example in Jordan)
- EN → AR, a British legal term that Arab readers would not know: *Ali has been sectioned*. → أودع عليّ مستشفى للأمراض النفسية بموجب القانون

Step 3: know when to use it

When readers do not need the source word, give the description alone, as in the last example. Use descriptive translation as your last option, because it makes the text longer. It suits cultural words and complex technical terms.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Translate for English readers: الوقف

2. Where can you put the description?

Check your answers

1. *waqf* (a charitable endowment in Islam).
2. In brackets after the word, or in a footnote.

REMEMBER

- Transliterate first, then describe.
- Describe only the first time a word appears.
- Use it as the last option.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Descriptive translation** (الترجمة الوصفية): Paraphrasing a source expression by describing its meaning. Also called explanatory translation (الترجمة الشرحية), Chapter 14).
- **Transliteration** (النقل الصوتي): Writing the sounds of a word in the letters of another language.
- **Concept** (المفهوم): An idea that a word or term stands for.

NEXT Chapter 17: Lexical creation

Chapter 17: Lexical creation

Where we are. When a word is needed again and again, a long explanation (Chapter 16) is not practical, and the language needs a new word. This chapter shows you how translators make one, and why you should search first.

Step 1: why new words are needed

Some cultural, religious, political or technical concepts have no equivalent, because the target language has a gap in its vocabulary. The translator then has to coin a word. This is called **lexical creation** (Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999/2011).

Step 2: five ways to make a word

1. **Neologism:** a new word, often derived from an Arabic root (الاشتقاق), or an old word with a new meaning. *blog* → مدوّنة (from دَوَّن, “to write down”); *cloud seeding* → الاستمطار (from مطر, “rain”). قطار once meant a line of camels; today it means a train.
2. **Loan translation (calque):** *smartphone* → الهاتف الذكي; *shadow government* → حكومة الظل; *Thanksgiving* → عيد الشكر
3. **Transliteration** (borrowing), with a short definition the first time: الصكوك → *sukuk* (Islamic investment certificates). Into Arabic, this is called Arabicisation (التعريب): *radio* → الراديو; *strategy* → استراتيجية; *technology* → تكنولوجيا
4. **Explanation:** a term that explains the idea instead of copying the parts (“green” + “washing”): *greenwashing* → التّضليل البيئي (companies falsely claiming that their products are environmentally friendly)
5. **Hybrid form:** part translated, part borrowed. *cybersecurity* → الأمن السيبراني

Arabic can also blend words into one, called البسمة from الحمدلة from بسم الله, الحمد لله, and in modern science, *amphibious* → برمائي (برّ + ماء).

Many English prefixes and suffixes have regular Arabic equivalents: *manageable* → قابل للإدارة; *antibiotic* → مضاد حيوي; *greenish* → مائل إلى الخضرة.

Step 3: search before you create

First search for an accepted term. The Arabic language academies, UNTERM (United Nations, n.d.) and Arabterm (ALECSO & GIZ, n.d.) record many new terms. For example: *global warming* → الاحترار العالمي; *greenhouse effect* → الاحتباس الحراري; *cancel culture* → ثقافة الإلغاء.

An accepted term is always better than a new invention. When a new word becomes widely accepted and enters the dictionary, it is **lexicalised** (المفعّمة).

DID YOU KNOW?

Words travel too. The Arabic قهوة passed into Turkish as *kahve*, into Italian as *caffè* and into English as *coffee*. English also took *sugar*, *cotton* and *zero* from Arabic, through other European languages.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Which method? *smartphone* → الهاتف الذكي
2. What should you do before creating a new word?

Check your answers

1. Loan translation (calque).
2. Search for an accepted term in the academies, UNTERM or Arabterm.

REMEMBER

- Create a new word only when no accepted term exists.
- The five methods: neologism, calque, transliteration, explanation and hybrid form.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Lexical creation** (التوليد المعجمي): Coining new target-language words for items with no direct equivalent.
- **Neologism** (اللفظ المستحدث): A new word, or an existing word given a new meaning.
- **Loan translation (calque)** (النسخ): Translating the parts of a compound word one by one.

NEXT Chapter 18: Text analysis

Part 6: Working with whole texts

Chapter 18: Text analysis

Where we are. So far you have worked with words and sentences. Now you move to whole texts. This chapter gives you a checklist for studying any text before you translate it.

Step 1: why study the text first?

Studying a text before translating it is called **text analysis** (Nord, 2005). It is the first of three phases: analysis, translation and commentary (Chapter 25). It helps you in several ways:

- Each new reading brings new ideas.
- You identify the field, the source and target audiences, the time, purpose, tone and genre.
- You find difficult terms early, so you translate faster.
- You choose your strategies and see what resources you need.
- You form a mental draft of the translation.

Begin “by reading the original for two purposes: first, to understand what it is about; second, to analyse it from a ‘translator’s’ point of view” (Newmark, 1988, p. 11).

Step 2: analyse, do not summarise

A **summary** gives only the facts. An **analysis** looks at who wrote the text, for whom, why and how. When asked to analyse, do not summarise.

Step 3: look at two levels

One useful model studies a text on two levels that complete each other: the **linguistic level** and the **external level** (Translation Team, n.d.; Fairclough, 2003).

The **linguistic level** is what you can see in the text. First look closely, at the **micro level**:

- **Words:** vocabulary, terms, figurative language, official titles, cultural expressions and references.
- **Grammar:** sentence structure, tenses, pronouns (first, second or third person) and how sentences are linked.
- **Meaning:** denotative, connotative, collocational, idiomatic and pragmatic meaning (Chapters 6 to 9).
- **Word forms:** prefixes and suffixes, compounds, acronyms and abbreviations.
- **Sound:** rhyme, rhythm and musicality, especially in poems, slogans and adverts.

Then look at the text as a whole, at the **macro level**:

- **The text:** its type, structure, genre, tone, level of formality and length, and any pictures or links (Chapter 19).
- **Other texts:** quotations from, or allusions to, other texts that readers are expected to recognise.
- **Point of view:** how the language supports a political or ideological position (Chapter 20).

The **external level** is the context in which the text was written. Ask: what event or background led to the text? Who is the author, and what does that tell you? How will the target culture and audience affect the translation?

Step 4: use the checklist

Answer these questions for every text:

1. Who is the author or speaker?
2. Who published it?
3. What is the field?
4. What is the genre and the purpose?
5. What is the tone, and what is the style of writing?
6. Who is the target audience?
7. Which terms and words need checking?

8. Which strategies will you use?

For example, take a short KUNA news report about relations between Kuwait and Australia. **Field:** politics. **Genre and purpose:** news report, to inform. **Tone:** neutral and straightforward. **Publisher:** KUNA. **Audience:** readers interested in Kuwait and the Middle East. **Style:** formal, with no short forms. **Strategy:** mostly literal, because the text has no metaphors.

Step 5: let the analysis guide you

A good analyst:

- keeps training their analytical skills;
- builds a personal model of analysis;
- makes the translation match the analysis: a formal tone means a formal translation;
- notes the text's problems, so the commentary can explain the solutions.

The same model also helps you judge a finished translation: check which elements were transferred correctly and which were left out (Chapter 23).

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. What is the difference between an analysis and a summary?
2. Name the three phases of translation.

Check your answers

1. A summary gives the facts; an analysis describes the features, background, purpose and style.
2. Analysis, translation and commentary.

REMEMBER

- Analyse **before** you translate.
- Your translation must match your analysis.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Text** (النص): Any piece of language, written or spoken, that forms a complete message: from a one-word sign to a whole book.
- **Text analysis** (تحليل النص): Breaking down and studying a text before translating it.
- **Genre** (نوع النص): A kind of text with its own rules, such as a news report, a contract or a poem.
- **Tone** (النبرة): The writer's attitude, for example neutral, critical or friendly.
- **Field** (المجال): The subject area of a text, such as politics, health or law.

NEXT Chapter 19: Text types and genres

Chapter 19: Text types and genres

Where we are. In Chapter 18 you learned to name a text's genre. This chapter shows you why the genre matters, with examples of the main genres.

Step 1: what is the text for?

Texts can be grouped by their main function (Reiss, 1971/2000). **Informative** texts give facts, **expressive** texts are creative and focus on form, as in literature, and **operative** texts persuade.

Step 2: each genre has its own rules

- **News:** facts, neutral tone and short headlines. *Oil prices rose sharply on Monday.* → ارتفعت أسعار النفط ارتفاعاً حاداً يوم الاثنين.
- **Legal:** exact words; *shall* expresses an obligation or a legal rule. *This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.* → تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت (the Arabic present tense, not سوف)
- **Political:** careful, sensitive words. *The two sides held frank and constructive talks.* → أجرى الجانبان محادثات صريحة وبناءة.

- **Medical:** no ambiguity and exact doses. *Take one tablet twice daily.* → تناول قرصاً واحداً مرتين يومياً.
- **Technical:** clear instructions and consistent terms. *Press and hold the power button.* → اضغط مطوّلاً على زرّ التشغيل.
- **Literary:** feeling, voice and natural dialogue. *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً شاقّاً.
- **Poetry:** images and rhythm, with more freedom. *الخيّل والليلّ والبيداء تعرفني* (al-Mutanabbi, n.d.) → *The horses, the night and the desert know me.*
- **Advertising:** persuasion and rhythm.

Step 3: translating news

English headlines have their own grammar:

- No *a*, *the* or *is*. A passive headline often becomes a verbal noun (مصدر) in Arabic: *Man killed, woman wounded in shooting* → مقتل رجل وإصابة امرأة في إطلاق نار.
- The simple present reports a recent event: *US launches air raids in Iraq* → الولايات المتحدة تشنّ غارات جوية في العراق.
- *to* + verb means the future: *Saudi Arabia to extend visa validity for expats* → السعودية ستمدّد فترة صلاحية تأشيرات الوافدين.
- Add what Arab readers may not know: *Mustang Referral Customer Complaint* → شكوى زبون فورد مستنّج من برنامج الإحالة (Ford and برنامج are added).

Most news stories give the most important facts first, in the headline and the first paragraph (the lead), and the details follow. This is the **inverted pyramid**. Keep this order in your translation.

Hard news reports facts, such as decisions, disasters and discoveries, without the writer's opinion. **Soft news** tells human stories, to interest or move the reader.

Step 4: technical and literary texts

In technical texts, one word can be a different term in each field: *depression* is الاكتئاب in psychology, الكساد in economics and منخفض جوي in a weather report. Check the field every time (Chapter 21).

In literary texts, **style** matters as much as content: word choice, sentence length, tone and dialogue. If a character speaks in dialect to show who they are, find a way to keep that effect.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Which text type is an advert: informative, expressive or operative?
2. Why does a medical text need exact words?

Check your answers

1. Operative: it tries to persuade.
2. Because a mistake, such as a wrong dose, can harm the reader.

REMEMBER

- Identify the genre before you translate.
- Follow the rules of the same genre in the target language.
- News headlines have their own grammar; translate them into natural Arabic headlines.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Text type** (نمط النص): A group of texts that share one main function: to inform, to express or to persuade.
- **Genre** (نوع النص): A kind of text with its own rules, such as a news report or a recipe.
- **Headline** (العنوان الرئيسي): The title of a news story.
- **Inverted pyramid** (الهرم المقلوب): A news structure that gives the most important facts first.

NEXT Chapter 20: Words and points of view

Chapter 20: Words and points of view

Where we are. After genre (Chapter 19), look for the writer's point of view, often hidden in single words. Three simple questions will help you find it.

Step 1: words are rarely neutral

Many word choices show a point of view, shaped by the writer's **ideology**, and your translation can keep, soften or strengthen it. A word that carries a judgement is a **loaded word**. Follow the client's policy on sensitive words (Chapter 2).

- *A suicide bomber killed ten people.* → انتحاري matches the English; استشهادي adds praise. The same person is seen from opposite points of view, so follow the client's policy.
- *regime or government* (حكومة or نظام): in many political texts, "regime" suggests criticism, but its meaning depends on the context and the source. Ask what judgement the word carries here.
- *Protesters were killed.* (قُتل متظاهرون): the passive hides who did the killing.

Step 2: ask three questions

Language is connected to power and society (Fairclough, 1992). This gives you three questions:

1. **The words:** which words show a judgement? Who is shown doing what, and who is hidden?
2. **The writer:** who wrote the text, for which newspaper or organisation, and for which readers?
3. **The purpose:** whose interests does the text serve?

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Why is *regime* not neutral?
2. What does the passive in *Protesters were killed* hide?

Check your answers

1. In many contexts it suggests a harsh or illegitimate government; check the context.

2. Who did the killing.

REMEMBER

- Notice loaded words and hidden doers.
- Follow the client's policy, and explain sensitive choices in your commentary (Chapter 25).

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Ideology** ((الأيديولوجيا) المنظومة الفكرية): A set of beliefs that shapes how people describe events.
- **Loaded word** (كلمة مشحونة دلاليًا): A word that carries a judgement, positive or negative.

NEXT Chapter 21: Terminology and terminology management

Part 7: Tools and resources

Chapter 21: Terminology and terminology management

Where we are. In Chapter 3 you learned to use dictionaries. This chapter looks at the special words of each field. By the end, you will be able to find, record and use them consistently.

Step 1: spot the special words in a text

In a contract or a medical leaflet, some words have one exact meaning in that field. These are **terms**. One wrong term can change the meaning of a contract or a medical instruction.

A term can also be several words that name one idea, such as *network security* (أمن الشبكات). Translate it as one unit.

The study of how terms are collected, named and managed is called **terminology** (Cabr  , 1999).

Terms often appear in short forms. Learn to recognise four kinds:

- **Initialism:** letters read one by one: *CIA*, *CBC* (complete blood count).
- **Acronym:** letters read as a word: *LASER*.
- **Abbreviation:** part of a word: *vol.* (volume).
- **Clipping:** a word cut short, often keeping its first part: *super* (superintendent).

Step 2: know who looks after terms

- A **translator** works across two languages and uses terms from glossaries, dictionaries and termbases.
- A **terminologist** studies the terms of a field rather than whole texts: they collect and record them, and sometimes create or standardise them, in one or more languages.

For Arabic, the Arabic language academies (مجامع اللغة العربية), for example in Cairo, Baghdad and Amman, create and approve terms (Translation Team, n.d.). There is also an academy in Damascus, and the Coordination Bureau of Arabization in Rabat (مكتب تنسيق التعريب) helps to unify them across the Arab world.

Step 3: translate a term

1. **Understand** its exact meaning in its field. In a medical text, *allergic* is أَرَجِيّ (everyday Arabic often says تحسّسي), an *allergen* is مادة مُحسّسة, and *contact eczema* is إكزيما التماس. If the field is new to you, read a short introduction first, such as an encyclopedia entry. If the meaning is still unclear, ask the client or a specialist.
2. **Look at its origin:** its parts often explain it, but the context decides: a *blackboard* can be green.
3. **Find the equivalent:** check the client's guide first, then the academies' term lists, UNTERM and Arabterm. Then confirm it in a text written in Arabic by specialists, not in a translation.
4. **If none exists**, think like a terminologist and create an accurate one (Chapter 17). A good term is clear and short, has one meaning, and follows the language's normal rules for making words. It does not say the same thing twice, as التطرّف الراديكالي does.
5. **Record** it in your term list, and **share** the list with your team.

Step 4: record your terms

Here is part of a simple term list:

English term	Arabic term	Field	Note
<i>governing law</i>	القانون الواجب التطبيق	Legal	Also القانون المطبّق; القانون الحاكم is a common calque
<i>provided that</i>	شريطة أن	Legal	A contract condition
<i>Article (of a law)</i>	مادة	Legal	A contract <i>clause</i> is بند
CBC	تعداد الدم الكامل	Medical	Also صورة الدم الكاملة

In your own list, add a column for the **source** where you checked each term, so that you and your team can verify it later. Other tools help too:

- **Specialised dictionary** (Chapter 3): the terms of one field.
- **Termbase**: each entry holds the term in each language, with its definition, field, source and date. A team can share and update it.
- **Terminology guide**: the client's approved terms and writing rules. Always ask for one, and follow it.

When you write a definition for your list, use one sentence: name the general group, then say what makes the term different. A *thermometer* (مقياس الحرارة) is an instrument that measures temperature.

Step 5: use one term for one idea

Suppose *Article* is مَادَّة in the first paragraph. Later you switch to بند “for variety”. Your reader now thinks you mean something new, because a new word suggests a new meaning.

When terms are not managed, one concept gets several names. Readers get confused, and earlier translations are harder to reuse. So use the same term throughout, and do not change an accepted term without a good reason.

Some concepts have two accepted names: *aerial* (British) and *antenna* (American) are both هوائي, and Arabic uses both حاسوب and كمبيوتر. Choose one, as the client's guide says, and note the other in your term list.

DID YOU KNOW?

The Arabic Language Academy in Damascus, founded in 1919, was the first of the modern Arabic language academies.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. What is the difference between a translator and a terminologist?
2. Is LASER an initialism or an acronym?
3. What should you do when no dictionary gives you the term?

Check your answers

1. A translator translates whole texts; a terminologist collects, records and sometimes standardises the terms of a field.
2. An acronym: the letters are read as a word.
3. Search the client's guide, UNTERM and Arabterm; if there is still no term, think like a terminologist: create an accurate equivalent and record it.

REMEMBER

- Keep a term list for every project, and ask for the client's guide.
- Search the academies, UNTERM and Arabterm before you create a term.
- Use one term for one idea.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Term** (المصطلح): A word or expression that names a concept in a special field.
- **Terminology** (علم المصطلح أو المصطلحية): The study, collection and management of specialised terms; also the set of terms used in one field.
- **Terminologist** (المصطلحي أو خبير المصطلحات): A specialist who collects, describes and records the terms of a field, and sometimes creates or standardises them, in one or more languages.
- **Term list** (قائمة المصطلحات): A list of the approved terms for a project, with their translations.
- **Termbase** (قاعدة بيانات المصطلحات أو بنك المصطلحات): A database of terms and information about them.
- **Terminology guide** (دليل المصطلحات): A document that tells translators which terms to use for a client.

NEXT Chapter 22: Machine translation and AI

Chapter 22: Machine translation and AI

Where we are. Many translators now work with software, from translation memories to AI chat tools. This chapter shows you what these tools do, where they go wrong, and how to correct their output safely.

Step 1: meet the tools

- **Machine translation:** early systems used rules, later ones statistics, and newer ones neural networks and AI. Each generation sounds more fluent, but every one can still be wrong.
- **Translation memory:** stores your past translations sentence by sentence and suggests them when a similar sentence appears. It saves time and keeps your work consistent.
- **Termbases:** help you keep one term for one idea across a project (Chapter 21).
- **CAT tools** combine these, for example Trados, memoQ, and the free OmegaT and Matecat.

Step 2: decide when a machine can help

Machine translation can help with some texts and tasks, but how reliable it is depends on the language pair, the field, the text type, the system and the quality needed. It is risky for legal, medical and religious texts, idioms, poetry and confidential texts.

Human review is needed whenever accuracy and accountability matter.

You, not the machine, are responsible for the final translation (Kenny, 2022).

Step 3: learn the machine's typical mistakes

- *It's raining cats and dogs.* → إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً: the idiom is translated word by word. Correct: تمطر بغزارة.
- *The doctor finished her shift.* → أنهى الطبيب نوبته: the machine made the doctor a man, although the English says *her*. Correct: أنهت الطبيبة نوبتها.
- AI tools may add facts that are not in the text. This is called **hallucination**.

Step 4: correct the machine's output

Our new branch opens on Monday. Don't miss out!

- Machine output: إفرعنا الجديد يفتح يوم الاثنين. لا تفوت الخروج. ✗ (*miss out* was read as "going out")
- Corrected: إيفتتح فرعنا الجديد يوم الاثنين. لا تفوتوا الفرصة. ✓

Correcting a machine translation like this is called **post-editing**. It has become a regular part of translators' work (Translation Team, n.d.). **Light** post-editing (التحرير (اللاحق الخفيف) makes the text accurate and understandable; **full** post-editing (التحرير (اللاحق الكامل) also makes it natural and ready to publish.

To post-edit, first compare the output with the source sentence by sentence. Then read it again as a normal text.

Step 5: use AI tools well, and adapt the whole product

- Tell the tool the text type, the audience and the terms you want.
- Ask for two or three options, then choose yourself.
- Check every name, number, date and term against a reliable source.

In localisation (Chapter 1), translation is only one part. Also adapt dates, numbers, currencies and units, images and colours, and the direction of the page: an Arabic website reads from right to left.

Step 6: follow four safety rules

1. You are responsible for every word.
2. Never put a client's private text into a public AI tool.
3. Check terms, names, numbers, idioms and every "not".
4. Tell the client if you used a machine or AI.

DID YOU KNOW?

In 1954, in a public demonstration in New York, a computer translated more than sixty Russian sentences into English. Its makers expected machine translation to be solved within a few years. Decades later, machines translate millions of words every day, and human translators are still needed to check them.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Should you paste a client's confidential contract into a free AI tool?

2. What is post-editing?

Check your answers

1. No, never.
2. A human correcting and improving machine translation.

REMEMBER

- Machine translation is a first draft, not a final translation.
- Always post-edit, and protect your client's privacy.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Machine translation (MT)** (الترجمة الآلية): Translation done by software, such as online translation tools or AI chat tools.
- **Post-editing** (التحرير اللاحق): A human correcting and improving machine translation output, lightly or fully.
- **Hallucination** (الهلوسة): Invented or false content produced by an AI tool, such as facts that are not in the source text.
- **Translation memory** (ذاكرة الترجمة): A database of earlier translations that the translator can reuse.
- **CAT tool** (أداة الترجمة بمساعدة الحاسوب): Computer-assisted translation software that helps a human translator, usually with a translation memory and a termbase.

NEXT Chapter 23: Revision and common mistakes

Part 8: Checking and explaining

Chapter 23: Revision and common mistakes

Where we are. You can now translate, with or without a machine. Next, you check your work before anyone else sees it. By the end, you will be able to revise a draft in three readings and spot common mistakes.

Step 1: read your draft three times

Every translator makes mistakes in a draft, even experts. Revision is where you find them. Checking your own draft is called **self-revision** (Mossop, 2014). Read it three times:

1. **With the original:** is anything missing, added or changed?
2. **Without the original:** does it sound natural? If a sentence sounds translated, rewrite it.
3. **The details:** numbers, names, spelling, punctuation, titles and captions.

Step 2: check your Arabic (EN → AR)

Each line shows a weak version, then a better one:

- Starting every sentence with the subject (correct, but it sounds translated):
...الحكومة أعلنت... → أعلنت الحكومة
- Overusing **قام ب:** قام الوزير بزيارة الكويت → زار الوزير الكويت
- Copying the English passive: تم افتتاح المعرض من قِبَل الوزير → افتتح الوزير المعرض
- Numbers 3 to 10: ثلاث طلاب → ثلاثة طلاب
- Hamza and taa marbuta: إنشاء، مدرسه، الى → إنشاء، مدرسة، إلى
- Word-for-word collocations: كسر القانون → خالف القانون
- English punctuation: نعم، سأحضر. هل ستحضر أنت؟ → نعم، سأحضر. هل ستحضر أنت؟ أنت؟

Step 3: check your English (AR → EN)

- Long sentences joined with “and”: split them with full stops.
- Repeated synonyms: *brave and daring* → *very brave*
- An extra “the”: *The life is beautiful.* → *Life is beautiful.*
- A missing “is”: *He in the office.* → *He is in the office.*
- Arabic prepositions: *He married from her.* → *He married her.*
- Missing capital letters in a title before a name: *minister of health Ahmad Ali* → *Minister of Health Ahmad Ali*

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Improve: *قام المدير بتوقيع العقد.*
2. Improve: *She is a doctor in the hospital and she works hard and she likes her job.*

Check your answers

1. *وقَّع المديرُ العقدَ.*
2. *She is a doctor at the hospital. She works hard and likes her job.*

REMEMBER

- Read your translation once **without** the original.
- If a sentence sounds translated, rewrite it.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Draft** (المسودة): The first version of a translation.
- **Revision** (المراجعة): Checking a translation against the source and correcting it.
- **Self-revision** (المراجعة الذاتية): Revising your own translation.

NEXT Chapter 24: Interlingual risk assessment

Chapter 24: Interlingual risk assessment

Where we are. Some mistakes do far more harm than others. This chapter gives you a simple table that shows where to check most carefully after revision (Chapter 23).

Step 1: see why some mistakes matter more

A wrong dose in a medicine leaflet or a missing “not” in a contract can cause real harm. So the more serious the possible harm, the more care a text needs. Seen this way, translating is a kind of **risk management** (Pym, 2015).

Step 2: look at the risk matrix

This table lists the main risk areas in English–Arabic translation, how serious each is, and what to do. It is called a **risk matrix**.

Risk area	Example	Risk level	What to do
Terms	<i>governing law</i> → القانون الواجب التطبيق	High in legal texts	Check a specialised dictionary and the term list
Negatives	A lost “not” reverses the meaning	High	Compare sentence by sentence
Numbers and dates	A wrong dose; Hijri or Gregorian date	High	Check every figure twice
Legal verbs	<i>shall</i> → سوف ✗	High in contracts	Use the Arabic present tense for obligations
Sensitive names	<i>Persian Gulf</i> / <i>Arabian Gulf</i>	Medium to high	Follow the client’s policy; explain in the commentary
Ideological words	انتحاري / استشهادي	Medium to high	Follow the client’s policy (Chapter 20)
Cultural images	<i>warmed my heart</i> → أثلج صدري, not أدفأ قلبي: coolness, not warmth, brings comfort in Arab culture	Medium	Use cultural approximation (Chapter 15)
Words with several meanings	عَلِمَ (flag), عِلْم (knowledge) or عِلِم (knew)?	Medium	Read the context (Chapter 7)
Style and register	A dialect word in a formal report	Low to medium	Re-read with the brief in mind

Risk area	Example	Risk level	What to do
Idioms	An idiom translated word by word	Medium	Check whether it is an idiom (Chapter 9)

Step 3: use the matrix before you deliver

1. Check your translation against each row.
2. Give most time to the high-risk areas.
3. For high-risk texts, such as legal and medical ones, ask a second person to check.

Example: *This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.* →

(سوف تخضع not). تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت

DID YOU KNOW?

In 1999, a spacecraft worth more than 100 million dollars, the *Mars Climate Orbiter*, was lost. One team gave its figures in imperial units, and another read them as metric units. A small mismatch between two systems caused a huge loss: always check numbers and units.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. What is the main risk in *Take one tablet twice daily*?
2. What should you do with a high-risk text?

Check your answers

1. The dose: the numbers must be exactly right.
2. Check it with extra care, and ask a second person to review it.

REMEMBER

- Check numbers, names, negatives, terms and legal verbs every time.
- The higher the risk, the more careful the check.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Risk** (الخطر): The chance that a choice causes a problem, and how serious it would be.
- **Risk management** (إدارة المخاطر): Spending more effort where a mistake could cause more harm.
- **Risk matrix** (مصفوفة تقييم المخاطر): A table of possible risks, how serious they are, and what to do.

NEXT Chapter 25: Translation commentary

Chapter 25: Translation commentary

Where we are. You can now translate and check a text. Often you must also explain your choices. This chapter shows you how to write a commentary, the third phase after analysis and translation.

Step 1: understand what a commentary is for

In a maths exam, you show your working, not just the answer. A **translation commentary** does the same for a translation: it shows your thinking. It sharpens your reasoning and helps you judge translations, your own and other people's (Dickins et al., 2016).

Step 2: plan the two parts

1. **Reflecting on your analysis:** which problems did it identify?
2. **Reflecting on your translation:** how did you solve each problem?

Keep your analysis (Chapter 18) open while you write, and refer to it: the commentary shows how the problems you found there were solved.

Step 3: answer five questions for each problem

1. **The problem:** what was difficult?

2. **The solution:** what did you write?
3. **The procedure or strategy:** which technique did you use (Chapters 10 to 17)?
4. **The resource:** which dictionary or source did you check?
5. **The justification:** why is your choice right for the reader?

Step 4: write it clearly

- Write in the **third person**: “The translator faced...”, “The translator changed some parts to make them more comprehensible...”.
- Let WH-questions guide you: what, why, how?
- Always give examples from the source and the translation.
- Explain omissions, for example: “This was omitted because it is irrelevant to the target audience.”
- Mention the dictionaries and resources you used.
- Keep it short and clear.

An example:

The source text says the agreement “remained a dead letter”. A literal translation, حرفاً ميتاً, would confuse Arab readers, so the translator chose the functional equivalent جبراً على ورق. The expression was checked in Arabic newspapers. It is a familiar idiom and suits the formal style of a news report.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. Write one commentary sentence for *strong tea* → شاي ثقيل.

Check your answers

1. For example: “*Strong tea* is a collocation, so a word-for-word translation would sound unnatural in Arabic. The translator therefore used the conventional Arabic collocation شاي ثقيل.”

REMEMBER

- Analysis → translation → commentary.
- For each problem: problem, solution, procedure or strategy, resource, justification.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Translation commentary** (التعليق على الترجمة): A text that explains the problems in a translation and justifies the solutions.
- **Justification** (التبرير): The reason why a translation choice is right.

NEXT *Translation quality checklist*

Translation quality checklist

Before you deliver any translation, go through this list. Each point is explained in Chapters 23 to 25.

Meaning

- ☐ Nothing is added.
- ☐ Nothing is left out.
- ☐ The meaning is transferred accurately.

Language

- ☐ The target text reads naturally.
- ☐ The grammar and spelling are checked.
- ☐ The level of formality suits the reader.

Terms and names

- ☐ Every term is checked in a reliable source.
- ☐ Each term is used consistently.
- ☐ Names and titles are correct.

Details and final reading

- ☐ Numbers, dates, units and punctuation are correct.
- ☐ Headings and formatting match the source.
- ☐ You have read the translation on its own, then side by side with the source.

Part 9: Audiovisual translation

Chapter 26: Introduction to audiovisual translation

Where we are. So far you have translated words on a page. Now you move to films, series and games, where words work with pictures and sound. By the end, you will know the main types and how to begin.

Step 1: see what makes a video different

Films, series, games and online videos are part of almost everyone's life today (Pérez-González, 2014). Driven by technology, **audiovisual translation** (AVT) is one of the fastest-growing areas of Translation Studies.

- It depends heavily on technology.
- **Images, sound** (dialogue, music, sound effects) and **written words** on screen work together to make meaning.
- The translator must connect the words with the pictures and sound (Gambier, 2003).

Step 2: know the main types

- **Subtitling:** written text on the screen (Chapter 27).
- **Dubbing:** new dialogue in the target language, often matched to the actors' lips.
- **Voice-over:** a translation read over the original voice, as in documentaries.
- **Audio description:** a spoken description of the action, for blind and partially sighted viewers.

Dubbing is used for cartoons, games and commercials, and in the Arab world for many children's programmes and series. Its challenges are matching lip movements, adapting cultural content and staying consistent across a series. When the cartoon *The Simpsons* was dubbed into Arabic as آل شمشون, the family's habits were adapted for Arab family viewers: Homer's beer, for example, became a soft drink (Translation Team, n.d.).

Step 3: put the purpose first

A cartoon for children and a documentary for adults need very different choices. So before you translate a video, ask what it is for and who will watch it. This idea is called **Skopos theory** (Reiss & Vermeer, 1984).

Step 4: prepare for the challenges

- **Culture:** a reference may have no equivalent (Chapters 15 to 17).
- **Language:** English and Arabic are built differently, yet you must be accurate and brief (Chapter 4).
- **Technology:** subtitles have strict limits of space and time.
- **Creativity:** jokes, wordplay, songs and slang need creative solutions.

Step 5: take your first steps

1. Watch the whole video first, then read the script or dialogue list.
2. Ask for the brief: subtitles or dubbing? For which viewers? In which Arabic?
3. Practise with free subtitling software, such as Subtitle Edit or Aegisub.
4. Watch films with Arabic subtitles and notice what the subtitler shortened.

DID YOU KNOW?

Before films had sound, the dialogue appeared on printed cards between the scenes, called *intertitles*. To show a silent film abroad, distributors simply replaced the cards with translated ones.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. What are the three elements of an audiovisual text?
2. Which type of AVT describes the action on screen for blind viewers?
3. What does Skopos theory put first?

Check your answers

1. Images, sound and written words.
2. Audio description.
3. The purpose of the translation.

REMEMBER

- AVT combines images, sound and words, and depends on technology.
- Main types: subtitling, dubbing, voice-over and audio description.
- The purpose and the viewers decide how you translate.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Audiovisual translation (AVT)** (الترجمة السمعية البصرية): Translating texts that combine words, images and sound, such as films and video games.
- **Dubbing** (الدبلجة): Replacing the original dialogue with recorded dialogue in the target language.
- **Voice-over** (التعليق الصوتي): Recording a translation over the original voice, which can still be heard quietly.
- **Audio description** (الوصف الصوتي): A spoken description of what happens on screen, for blind and partially sighted viewers.
- **Skopos theory** (نظرية الغاية): The idea that the purpose of a translation decides how it is translated.

NEXT Chapter 27: Subtitling

Chapter 27: Subtitling

Where we are. Chapter 26 introduced audiovisual translation. Now you will focus on subtitles. By the end, you will be able to write and check a subtitle, and handle cultural references and strong language.

Step 1: learn the limits of a subtitle

Viewers read while they watch, so a subtitle normally has one or two lines. Each line traditionally holds about 37 to 39 characters; some streaming platforms allow up to 42. It must stay on screen long enough to be read, usually from about one to six or seven seconds. It must also appear and disappear with the speech: marking these in

and out times is called **spotting** (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2021). **These are common conventions, not universal rules: always follow the client's or the platform's style guide.**

There are several kinds:

- **Intralingual:** the same language as the dialogue, for example subtitles for the deaf and hard of hearing (**SDH**), which also describe important sounds, or subtitles for language learners.
- **Interlingual:** another language; what translators usually make.
- **Pre-prepared** (offline) or **live** (online), as in live news.
- **Open** (burned into the picture) or **closed** (can be turned on and off).

Step 2: subtitle a clip

1. Watch the whole film or video, with the dialogue list if you have one.
2. **Spot** the subtitles: mark when each one starts and ends.
3. Translate the meaning of each line.
4. **Condense:** cut what viewers can see or do not need, such as repetitions and fillers like *well* and *you know*.
5. Check the length, reading time and line breaks, then watch the video with your subtitles.

A famous line shows how Arabic can say the same thing in less space. In *The Godfather* (Coppola, 1972), Vito Corleone says:

"I'm gonna make him an offer he can't refuse."

سَأَقْدِمُ لَهُ عَرْضاً لَا يُرْفَضُ.

English needs a subject and a modal in a second clause (*he can't refuse*). Arabic uses one passive verb, لَا يُرْفَضُ, so the subtitle is shorter, it fits the screen, and the quiet threat stays.

Step 3: write good Arabic subtitles

- Choose the variety of Arabic for the audience, the genre, the characters and the platform, following the client's guidelines: Modern Standard Arabic suits most content, while a dialect may be right when a character's identity or way of speaking matters.
- Break a line where the meaning breaks: keep a noun with its adjective, a preposition with its noun, and pairs such as مدير المدرسة together.
- Use Arabic punctuation.
- Work with the images, dialogue, music and sound effects. If the picture already shows something, the subtitle can be shorter. If the words refer to something on screen, make sure the subtitle still matches it.

It is not easy. Viewers who know some of the source language hear the original and read your translation, so they notice mistakes. Speech must be cut down to short written lines. And how characters speak shows who they are: their **sociolect** (social group), **slang** and **idiolect** (personal habits). Even in MSA, try to keep some of this through your choice of words. Into English, look for an expression with the same tone: a Kuwaiti character who says الحجي معاك ضايع can be subtitled *It's like talking to a brick wall* (Mu'jam al-ta'ābīr, n.d.).

Step 4: handle cultural references

Cultural references, or **culture-bound terms**, may be **geographical** (places), **ethnographic** (food, holidays, daily life) or **socio-political** (government, institutions) (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2007).

The most useful strategies are (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2007; Pedersen, 2011):

1. **Loan** (retention): keep the source word.
2. **Calque** (direct translation): translate it word for word.
3. **Explicitation** (specification): add a little information.
4. **Generalisation**: use a more general word.
5. **Substitution**: use something familiar to the audience.
6. **Official equivalent**: use the accepted translation, if there is one.

7. **Compensation:** make up for a lost effect somewhere else.
8. **Omission:** leave it out when it is unimportant and there is no space.

You met most of these in Chapters 13 and 14. In subtitling, you must also respect limits of space and time.

Step 5: handle strong and taboo language

Films use swearing and other forbidden words for realism, character or humour. This is called **taboo language**. Subtitlers often soften it, for several reasons: swear words look stronger in writing than in speech; audiences have different norms; and broadcasters or authorities may require it (**censorship**), or subtitlers may choose it themselves (self-censorship). Follow the client's guidelines, and keep the emotion of the scene where you can.

The last line of *Gone with the Wind* (Fleming, 1939) is a good test: “*Frankly, my dear, I don’t give a damn.*” In 1939 *damn* was shocking on screen. A subtitle such as *بصراحة* لم يعد الأمر يعني لي يا عزيزتي keeps the coldness and the finality of the line without a swear word: the emotion survives, the word is softened.

Try it

Practise what you have just learned. Answer on your own first, then check your answers below.

1. What is the difference between open and closed subtitles?
2. Which strategy uses an accepted translation?
3. Why do viewers notice mistakes in subtitles easily?

Check your answers

1. Open subtitles are burned into the picture; closed subtitles can be turned on and off.
2. The official equivalent.
3. Because they hear the original and read the translation at the same time, and many understand some of the original.

REMEMBER

- A subtitle normally has no more than two short lines, stays on screen long enough to be read, and works with images and sound.
- Choose a strategy for each cultural reference, within the limits of space and time.
- Follow the client's guidelines on strong language.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Subtitling** (السترجة أو الترجمة المرئية): Showing a written version of the dialogue, usually at the bottom of the screen, together with important on-screen text and song lyrics.
- **Dialogue list** (قائمة الحوار): A written script of everything said in a film, given to the translator.
- **Culture-bound term** (مصطلح ذو خصوصية ثقافية): A reference to something from one culture, such as a food or a holiday. Also called a culture-specific item (Chapter 15).
- **Taboo language** (اللغة المحظورة): Words that a society or religion forbids or restricts, such as swear words.
- **Censorship** (الرقابة): Removing or changing content that is considered unacceptable.

NEXT *Put it all together*

Put it all together

You have now met every step of the work. Translate this short press release into Arabic for a Kuwaiti newspaper, one step at a time.

The College of Arts will hold its first Translation Week from 3 to 7 March, bringing together students, professional translators and representatives of government ministries. The programme includes workshops on legal and medical translation, a panel discussion on machine translation, and a subtitling competition for undergraduate teams.

“Translation is no longer a quiet job done behind closed doors,” the organising committee said in a statement. “Every ministry, hospital and newsroom depends on it.”

Registration is free, but places are limited. Students must register through the university portal by 20 February, and all participants will receive a certificate of attendance.

1. **Brief:** who might ask for this translation, for what purpose, and for which readers (Chapter 2)?
2. **Analysis:** what is the genre, the tone and the level of formality (Chapters 18 and 19)?
3. **Research:** check *panel discussion*, *subtitling competition*, *university portal* and *certificate of attendance* (Chapters 3 and 21).
4. **First draft:** think about word order and natural collocations (Chapters 4 and 8).
5. **Problems:** does Arabic share the image in *behind closed doors* (Chapter 12)? How will you present the quotation and the dates (Chapter 24)?
6. **Solutions:** name the procedure or strategy you used for each problem (Chapters 13 and 14).
7. **Revision:** use the Translation quality checklist, then read your final version once more as an Arab reader would.
8. **Commentary:** in about 100 words, explain your three most important decisions (Chapter 25).

When in doubt

When you do not know a word

1. Read the context around it (Chapter 7).
2. Check a bilingual dictionary, then a monolingual one (Chapter 3).
3. See how the word is used in texts written in the target language.
4. For a term, check a specialist source such as UNTERM or Arabterm (Chapter 21).
5. Compare the options, and choose the one that fits the context.

When two translations seem possible

- Which one fits the context?
- Which one fits the audience and the purpose (Chapter 2)?
- Which one keeps the function of the original (Chapter 10)?
- Which one sounds natural in the target language?
- Which one keeps your terms consistent (Chapter 21)?

When a machine or AI tool gives you an answer

- Check it against the source, sentence by sentence (Chapter 22).
- Check the terms.
- Look for anything missing or added.
- Look for invented facts, names or numbers.
- Check the style and the level of formality.
- Remember that a fluent sentence is not always an accurate one.

Your journey continues

You started this book with one sentence from a news report. You can now plan a translation, understand a text, write it naturally in the other language, and check it. Here is how to keep growing.

Build a daily habit

- Read something in English and something in Arabic every day. Good translators are good readers first.
- Keep a translation notebook. Write down the collocations, idioms and terms you meet, with their equivalents (Chapters 8, 9 and 21).
- Translate a short text often, even one paragraph. Revise it the next day with fresh eyes (Chapter 23).

Learn from real translations

- Compare texts published in both languages. The United Nations, for example, publishes its documents in six official languages, including Arabic and English. Put the two versions side by side and ask why each choice was made. Then show your own work to others: every correction teaches you something.

Choose where to go next

Translation opens many doors. You can specialise in legal, medical, technical, literary or news translation, in subtitling and dubbing (Part 9), in the localisation of apps and games, or in interpreting, which is translating speech. The Further reading list suggests where to start.

The Guild Translation Team works on real translation projects, and new members are welcome. Scan the QR code on the back cover to visit the team's website.

Every translation is a bridge between two peoples. Build yours with care, and enjoy the crossing.

Abbreviations

- **AI:** artificial intelligence (الذكاء الاصطناعي)
- **AR → EN:** from Arabic into English
- **AVT:** audiovisual translation (الترجمة السمعية البصرية)
- **CAT:** computer-assisted translation (الترجمة بمساعدة الحاسوب)
- **EN → AR:** from English into Arabic
- **MSA:** Modern Standard Arabic (الفصحى المعاصرة)
- **MT:** machine translation (الترجمة الآلية)
- **SDH:** subtitles for the deaf and hard of hearing
- **SL:** source language (اللغة المصدر); **SLC:** source language culture (ثقافة اللغة المصدر)
- **ST:** source text (النص المصدر)
- **TL:** target language (اللغة الهدف); **TLC:** target language culture (ثقافة اللغة الهدف)
- **TS:** Translation Studies (دراسات الترجمة)
- **TT:** target text (النص الهدف)

Further reading

If you want to go further, start with these books. Full details are in the References.

- **Baker (2018)**, *In other words*: the classic coursebook, with problems and strategies at word, grammar and text level.
- **Ghazala (2008)**, *Translation as problems and solutions*: English–Arabic examples of common problems, each with its solutions.
- **Dickins et al. (2016)**, *Thinking Arabic translation*: a practical course in translating from Arabic into English.
- **Newmark (1988)**, *A textbook of translation*: methods and procedures, with many examples.
- **Díaz Cintas and Remael (2021)**, *Subtitling*: a practical guide to the subtitler's work, with many examples.

Glossary

All the key terms defined in this handbook, in alphabetical order, with the chapter where each one is explained. Where two Arabic equivalents are joined by أو, the first is the one this handbook prefers.

Adaptation (method) التكيف A very free rewriting; some specialists see it as a new text, not a translation. (Chapter 11)

Adaptation (procedure) التكيف Replacing a cultural situation with a familiar one; smaller in scale than adaptation as a method (Chapter 11). (Chapter 13)

Addition الإضافة Adding words or information that the reader needs. (Chapter 14)

Approximation التقريب Rendering the meaning of the source text as closely as possible in the target language, knowing that an exact match is impossible. (Chapter 1)

Audio description الوصف الصوتي A spoken description of what happens on screen, for blind and partially sighted viewers. (Chapter 26)

Audiovisual translation (AVT) الترجمة السمعية البصرية Translating texts that combine words, images and sound, such as films and video games. (Chapter 26)

Bilingual dictionary معجم ثنائي اللغة A dictionary that gives equivalents in another language. (Chapter 3)

Borrowing الاقتراض Taking a word from the source language as it is. (Chapter 13)

Calque النسخ Translating each part of an expression literally; also called loan translation (Chapter 17). (Chapter 13)

CAT tool أداة الترجمة بمساعدة الحاسوب Computer-assisted translation software that helps a human translator, usually with a translation memory and a termbase. (Chapter 22)

Censorship الرقابة Removing or changing content that is considered unacceptable. (Chapter 27)

Client العميل The person or organisation that asks for a translation. (Chapter 2)

Collocation التلازم اللفظي Words that naturally go together; the company a word keeps. (Chapter 8)

Collocations dictionary معجم المتلازمات اللفظية A dictionary of the natural word partners of a language. (Chapter 3)

Commissioned translator مترجم بتكليف A translator who translates a text at someone else's request. (Chapter 1)

Communicative purpose الغرض التواصلي What the translation is for: to inform, persuade, instruct or entertain. (Chapter 2)

Communicative translation الترجمة التواصلية Translating the meaning in context so that the reader understands and accepts it easily, as a target-language writer would say it. (Chapter 11)

Compensation التعويض Making up for an effect lost in one place by creating a similar effect elsewhere. (Chapter 14)

Concept المفهوم An idea that a word or term stands for. (Chapter 16)

Connotation المعنى الإيحائي The extra feeling or association a word carries. (Chapter 6)

Context السياق Everything around a word or text that helps us understand it: the surrounding words and the wider situation. (Chapter 7)

Cultural approximation التقريب الثقافي Bringing the source text's cultural meaning as close as possible to the target reader. (Chapter 15)

Cultural substitution الاستبدال الثقافي Replacing a cultural reference with one that is familiar to the target reader. (Chapter 14)

Culture-bound term مصطلح ذو خصوصية ثقافية A reference to something from one culture, such as a food or a holiday. Also called a culture-specific item (Chapter 15). (Chapter 27)

Culture-specific item عنصر ذو خصوصية ثقافية A word, custom or reference that belongs to one culture. (Chapter 15)

Denotation المعنى المعجمي The basic, dictionary meaning of a word. (Chapter 6)

Descriptive translation الترجمة الوصفية Paraphrasing a source expression by describing its meaning. Also called explanatory translation (الترجمة الشرحية, Chapter 14). (Chapter 16)

Dialect اللهجة العامية The everyday spoken Arabic of a country or region. (Chapter 4)

Dialogue list قائمة الحوار A written script of everything said in a film, given to the translator. (Chapter 27)

Domestication التوطين Making a translation feel local to the target reader. (Chapter 14)

Draft المسودة The first version of a translation. (Chapter 23)

Dubbing الدبلجة Replacing the original dialogue with recorded dialogue in the target language. (Chapter 26)

Equivalence التكافؤ A match between a source-language expression and a target-language expression. (Chapter 10)

Equivalence (procedure) التكافؤ Describing the same situation with a completely different expression, often an idiom or a proverb; narrower than equivalence in general (Chapter 10). (Chapter 13)

Explanatory translation الترجمة الشرحية Explaining a word or expression that has no equivalent. (Chapter 14)

Explication التصريح Stating in the target text information that the source text only implies. (Chapter 14)

Field المجال The subject area of a text, such as politics, health or law. (Chapter 18)

Figurative language اللغة المجازية Language used in a non-literal way to create an image or effect. (Chapter 12)

Fixed expression العبارة المسكوكة A fixed group of words whose meaning is clear from its words, such as *as a matter of fact*. (Chapter 9)

Foreignisation التغريب Keeping the foreign flavour of the source text. (Chapter 14)

Form الشكل The structure of language: a word, phrase, clause, sentence or text. (Chapter 5)

Formal equivalence التكافؤ الشكلي Keeping the form of the original: passive for passive, verb for verb. (Chapter 10)

Free translation الترجمة الحرة Keeping the message but not the form; also called loose translation. (Chapter 11)

Functional equivalence التكافؤ الوظيفي Using a target-language expression that serves the same function, whatever its form. (Chapter 10)

Functional translation الترجمة الوظيفية Translating with a target-language expression that has the same function. (Chapter 14)

Genre نوع النص A kind of text with its own rules, such as a news report, a contract or a poem. (Chapter 18)

Hallucination الهلوسة Invented or false content produced by an AI tool, such as facts that are not in the source text. (Chapter 22)

Headline العنوان الرئيسي The title of a news story. (Chapter 19)

Homonymy المشترك اللفظي One word with several meanings that are not related. (Chapter 7)

Ideational equivalence التكافؤ الفكري Giving only the basic idea, in plain words. (Chapter 10)

Ideology المنظومة الفكرية (الأيديولوجيا) A set of beliefs that shapes how people describe events. (Chapter 20)

Idiom التعبير الاصطلاحي A fixed expression whose meaning is not the sum of the meanings of its words. (Chapter 9)

Implication الإضمار Leaving implied in the target text information that the reader can understand from the context. (Chapter 14)

Interpreting الترجمة الشفهية Transferring spoken language into another language. (Chapter 1)

Inverted pyramid الهرم المقلوب A news structure that gives the most important facts first. (Chapter 19)

Justification التبرير The reason why a translation choice is right. (Chapter 25)

Lexical creation التوليد المعجمي Coining new target-language words for items with no direct equivalent. (Chapter 17)

Lexical gap الفجوة المعجمية A concept that has a word in one language but not in the other. (Chapter 6)

Literal translation الترجمة الحرفية Keeping the original words, changing only what grammar requires; also called modified literal translation (الترجمة الحرفية المعدلة). (Chapter 11)

Loaded word كلمة مشحونة دلاليًا A word that carries a judgement, positive or negative. (Chapter 20)

Loan translation (calque) النسخ Translating the parts of a compound word one by one. (Chapter 17)

Machine translation (MT) الترجمة الآلية Translation done by software, such as online translation tools or AI chat tools. (Chapter 22)

Macro context سياق الموقف (الخارجي) The wider situation: the author, audience, time, place and circumstances of a text. (Chapter 7)

Meaning المعنى The idea that a form expresses. (Chapter 5)

Mental draft المسودة الذهنية A first idea of the translation that you form while reading the text. (Chapter 2)

Metaphor الاستعارة A comparison without “as” or “like”; using a word in a non-basic meaning. (Chapter 12)

Micro context (co-text) السياق اللغوي (الداخلي) The words and sentences immediately around a word. (Chapter 7)

Modern Standard Arabic (MSA) الفصحى المعاصرة The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education. (Chapter 4)

Modulation التطويع Expressing the same idea from another point of view. (Chapter 13)

Monolingual dictionary معجم أحادي اللغة A dictionary that explains words in the same language. (Chapter 3)

Neologism اللفظ المستحدث A new word, or an existing word given a new meaning. (Chapter 17)

Omission الحذف Leaving out words that are unnecessary in the target language. (Chapter 14)

Polysemy تعدّد المعنى One word with several meanings that are related. (Chapter 7)

Post-editing التحرير اللاحق A human correcting and improving machine translation output, lightly or fully. (Chapter 22)

Proverb المثل A traditional saying that gives advice or states a truth. (Chapter 9)

Register المستوى اللغوي How formal or informal the language is. (Chapter 4)

Revision المراجعة Checking a translation against the source and correcting it. (Chapter 23)

Risk الخطر The chance that a choice causes a problem, and how serious it would be. (Chapter 24)

Risk management إدارة المخاطر Spending more effort where a mistake could cause more harm. (Chapter 24)

Risk matrix مصفوفة تقييم المخاطر A table of possible risks, how serious they are, and what to do. (Chapter 24)

Self-initiated translator مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية A translator who chooses a text to translate on their own initiative. (Chapter 1)

Self-revision المراجعة الذاتية Revising your own translation. (Chapter 23)

Sentence meaning معنى الجملة What the words of a sentence say. (Chapter 6)

Simile التشبيه A comparison that uses “as” or “like”. (Chapter 12)

Skopos theory نظرية الغاية The idea that the purpose of a translation decides how it is translated. (Chapter 26)

Source text (ST) النص المصدر The original text that you translate. (Chapter 1)

Speaker meaning مقصد المتكلم What the speaker really means by saying it. (Chapter 6)

Specialised dictionary معجم متخصص A dictionary for one field, such as law or medicine. (Chapter 3)

Subtitling السترجة أو الترجمة المرئية Showing a written version of the dialogue, usually at the bottom of the screen, together with important on-screen text and song lyrics. (Chapter 27)

Taboo language اللغة المحظورة Words that a society or religion forbids or restricts, such as swear words. (Chapter 27)

Target audience الجمهور المستهدف The people who will read the translation. (Chapter 2)

Target text (TT) النص الهدف Your translation. (Chapter 1)

Term المصطلح A word or expression that names a concept in a special field. (Chapter 21)

Term list قائمة المصطلحات A list of the approved terms for a project, with their translations. (Chapter 21)

Termbase قاعدة بيانات المصطلحات أو بنك المصطلحات A database of terms and information about them. (Chapter 21)

Terminologist المصطلحي أو خبير المصطلحات A specialist who collects, describes and records the terms of a field, and sometimes creates or standardises them, in one or more languages. (Chapter 21)

Terminology علم المصطلح أو المصطلحية The study, collection and management of specialised terms; also the set of terms used in one field. (Chapter 21)

Terminology guide دليل المصطلحات A document that tells translators which terms to use for a client. (Chapter 21)

Text النص Any piece of language, written or spoken, that forms a complete message: from a one-word sign to a whole book. (Chapter 18)

Text analysis تحليل النص Breaking down and studying a text before translating it. (Chapter 18)

Text type نمط النص A group of texts that share one main function: to inform, to express or to persuade. (Chapter 19)

Tone النبرة The writer's attitude, for example neutral, critical or friendly. (Chapter 18)

Translation الترجمة Transferring meaning from one language into

another. In a narrow sense, written translation (الترجمة التحريرية), as opposed to interpreting. (Chapter 1)

Translation brief موجز الترجمة The client's instructions for a translation: who it is for, what it is for and any other requirements. (Chapter 2)

Translation commentary التعليق على الترجمة A text that explains the problems in a translation and justifies the solutions. (Chapter 25)

Translation memory ذاكرة الترجمة A database of earlier translations that the translator can reuse. (Chapter 22)

Translation procedure إجراء الترجمة A technique for translating a word, phrase or sentence. (Chapter 13)

Translation strategy استراتيجية الترجمة A planned solution to a translation problem. (Chapter 14)

Transliteration النقل الصوتي Writing the sounds of a word in the letters of another language. (Chapter 16)

Transposition الإبدال Changing the word class, for example a noun into a verb. (Chapter 13)

Verbal sentence الجملة الفعلية A sentence that starts with a verb. (Chapter 4)

Voice-over التعليق الصوتي Recording a translation over the original voice, which can still be heard quietly. (Chapter 26)

Word order ترتيب الكلمات The order of the subject, verb and object in a sentence. (Chapter 4)

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